

Proofs for the Existence of God — Premium Solved-PYQ and Practice Workbook

UPSC Philosophy Optional · Paper II · Section B · Philosophy of Religion · Syllabus item 2 · 2026 Edition

Companion to: Proofs for the Existence of God and their Critique — Complete Learning Session (10 August 2026)

How to use this workbook

1. Read the demand decoding table, then close the model answer and write to time.
2. Compare your script against the "What a top Philosophy Optional answer must contain" block, not merely against the conclusion.
3. Attempt every MCQ before reading the explanation. The key rotates strictly $A \rightarrow B \rightarrow C \rightarrow D$, repeated eight times across the 32 questions.
4. In every Mains answer, preserve the philosophical sequence: classify $\rightarrow$ reconstruct as premises $\rightarrow$ expose a presupposition $\rightarrow$ objection $\rightarrow$ reply $\rightarrow$ graded verdict.
5. Never conflate the four things a critique may attack: validity, soundness of the premises, the attributes of the being reached, and the passage from that being to the God of religion.

Note on exam stage. Philosophy is a Mains-only Optional. It has no Prelims paper and no GS-overlap objective component, so no Prelims PYQs are included or required. Part I therefore contains the complete set of verified Mains PYQs owned by this topic; the MCQs in Part II are original diagnostic instruments, not past objective questions.

Part I — All 12 Verified Topic-Owned PYQs (2018–2025)

Corpus note: ✓ The audited Paper II corpus for 2018–2025 contains 12 primary-owned question-parts for this syllabus item, out of 112 parts overall. The corpus is continuous across all eight years. Cross-linked questions owned by Notions of God, Reason–Revelation–Faith or Soul, Immortality, Rebirth and Liberation are not duplicated here.

#	Year	Q	Marks	Theme
1	2018	Q6(c)	15	Ontological — concept and existence
2	2018	Q8(a)	20	Aquinas' Five Ways vs Nyāya
3	2018	Q8(b)	15	Buddhist arguments against a creator
4	2019	Q5(e)	10	Jaina proofs
5	2020	Q6(a)	20	Is Anselm's proof logical?
6	2021	Q7(b)	15	Moral argument
7	2022	Q6(a)	20	Five Ways; most interesting
8	2022	Q8(a)	20	A priori vs a posteriori
9	2023	Q7(a)	20	Nyāya arguments
10	2024	Q7(c)	15 (10+5)	Ontological proof with criticism

#	Year	Q	Marks	Theme
11	2025	Q6(a)	20	Design argument with Hume's criticism
12	2025	Q7(b)	15	Nyāya proofs

PYQ 1 — 2018, Q6(c), 15 marks

Exact question

"Does the concept of God entail the existence of God? Examine from the perspective of ontological argument."

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	Examine — analyse the entailment claim and deliver a reasoned verdict; not a narrative of Anselm's life
Core issue	Whether conceptual analysis can establish instantiation
Scope boundary	Stay inside the ontological family; do not drift into Aquinas or Nyāya
Ideal thesis	The concept entails necessary existence conditionally — if God exists, God exists necessarily — but conceptual entailment cannot deliver instantiation
Non-negotiables	Both forms of Anselm; Descartes; Gaunilo; Kant; the modal repair and its possibility-premise burden

Model answer (~240 words)

The ontological argument claims a unique entailment: that the very concept of God contains, and therefore yields, God's existence. Anselm defines God as "that than which nothing greater can be conceived", where "greater" means more perfect. In Proslogion 2 he argues by reductio: if this being existed only in the understanding, a greater could be conceived — namely the same being existing in reality as well — which contradicts the definition. In Proslogion 3 the claim is strengthened: a being that cannot be thought not to exist is greater than one that can; God therefore exists necessarily, by aseity. Descartes recasts this through essence-containment: existence belongs to a supremely perfect being as three angles belong to a triangle.

The entailment fails at a precise point. Gaunilo's perfect-island parody shows the form proves too much; Anselm replies that only God is defined with necessary, non-contingent existence, which an island by definition lacks. That reply protects the second form but shifts the burden onto the coherence of maximal greatness. Kant's objection is decisive: existence is not a real predicate. A hundred real thalers contain no more concept than a hundred possible ones; existence posits an object rather than enriching a concept. Chatterjee and Datta restate this in the Indian idiom of a hundred rupees imagined in one's pocket.

Modal reconstructions retain necessary existence but transfer the whole weight to the possibility premise, which a parallel possibility-of-non-existence can offset.

Verdict: the concept entails existence hypothetically, not actually. Conceptual analysis yields a conditional, never an instantiation.

What a top Philosophy Optional answer must contain

- Structure: state the entailment claim → both Anselmian forms → Descartes → Gaunilo and reply → Kant → modal repair → conditional verdict.
- Doctrine: aliquid quo nihil maius cogitari possit; aseity; necessary versus contingent existence.
- Argument: the reductio must be reproduced as steps, not paraphrased as a slogan.

- Distinction: conceptual entailment versus instantiation; Anselm's comparative form versus Descartes' essence-containment form.
- Technical terms: real predicate, determining predicate, necessary existence, possibility premise.
- Criticism: Gaunilo attacks the form; Kant attacks the logic of existence. Do not merge them.
- Comparison: one line noting that Indian philosophy has no a priori analogue, for pramāṇa-theoretic reasons.
- Conclusion: a conditional entailment verdict — the strongest available and the one the question invites.

Compact skeleton and timing

1 min : State the entailment claim precisely
 4 min : Proslogion 2 and 3 as numbered steps; Descartes
 3 min : Gaunilo + Anselm's reply; note the shifted burden
 3 min : Kant – existence is not a real predicate; thaler illustration
 2 min : Modal repair; possibility-premise burden
 1 min : Verdict – hypothetical entailment, not instantiation
 Total : 14 minutes

Common mistakes and examiner penalties

- Writing only Proslogion 2 and omitting necessary existence: loses Anselm's reply to Gaunilo entirely.
- Attributing the island to Kant or the thaler to Gaunilo: factual error, heavily penalised.
- Answering "yes, God exists" or "no, God does not exist": the question is about entailment, not theology.
- Importing the cosmological argument: out of scope.
- Saying the modal version "refutes Kant": overstatement; the burden merely migrates.
- Concluding without distinguishing conceptual from actual entailment: the whole point of the question missed.

PYQ 2 — 2018, Q8(a), 20 marks

Exact question

"Compare St. Thomas Aquinas' five ways of knowing God with the arguments of the Nyāya School of Indian Philosophy for the existence of God."

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	Compare — a sustained axis-by-axis comparison, not two separate essays
Core issue	Whether two independent a posteriori natural theologies reach the same God by the same route
Scope boundary	Both sets of arguments must be reconstructed; neither may be reduced to a label
Ideal thesis	Structural convergence in inferring intelligence from order; decisive divergence over material causation and the role of karma
Non-negotiables	All five Ways named; at least four Nyāya arguments named in Sanskrit; the efficient/material cause distinction

Model answer (≈345 words)

Aquinas and the Naiyāyikas both practise a posteriori natural theology: each begins from a general feature of the world and argues to an ultimate intelligent reality. Their convergence is real, and so is their divergence.

Aquinas' Five Ways (Summa Theologiae I, q.2, a.3) argue from change to a prime mover; from efficient causation to a first cause; from contingency to a necessary being; from degrees of perfection to a maximum; and from purposive regularity in non-cognitive nature to a divine intelligence. The regress he excludes is essentially ordered — the stick moves the stone only while the hand moves the stick — so "first" means explanatory priority, not the earliest event in time.

Nyāya's Īśvara-anumāna proceeds through several routes. Kāryāt: composite objects are effects, since they are made of parts (sāvaṃyava) and possess intermediate magnitude (avāntara-mahattva); material causes cannot achieve the required order and co-ordination without an intelligent maker, who must be omniscient, since only such a being can directly know atoms. Āyojanāt: inert atoms need purposive combination. Dhṛtyādeḥ: the world's support and dissolution require governance. Padāt / śruteḥ: Vedic authority presupposes an omniscient author. Finally, the argument from adṛṣṭa: the unconscious stock of merit and demerit cannot allot determinate joys and sorrows, so God is karmaphaladātā.

The convergence: both infer intelligence from order; both add attributes stepwise rather than by definition; both are cumulative rather than single-inference systems, Udayana multiplying routes exactly as Aquinas multiplies Ways.

The divergence is decisive. Aquinas' God is the cause of being, creating ex nihilo; Nyāya's Īśvara is the efficient cause only, ordering eternal, uncreated atoms while souls, space, time and adṛṣṭa remain co-present with Him. Aquinas' proofs are praeambula fidei drawn from reason alone; two Nyāya arguments are explicitly scriptural. Aquinas' God is unconditioned; Nyāya's is morally constrained by adṛṣṭa.

Consequently the critiques differ in weight. Hume's analogy objection strikes Nyāya hardest, since its inference is expressly artefact-modelled on pot and potter; while the redundancy objection — that karma and atoms could operate without a supervisor — is uniquely Indian and, as C. D. Sharma presses it, uniquely damaging.

Verdict: the same inferential architecture, but not the same God: Aquinas' terminus is metaphysically ultimate, Nyāya's is cosmically administrative.

What a top Philosophy Optional answer must contain

- Structure: a comparative frame first, then axis-by-axis treatment — never two disconnected halves.
- Doctrine: all five Ways correctly identified; at least four Nyāya routes with Sanskrit terms.
- Argument: the essentially ordered series and the sāvaṃyava / avāntara-mahattva criteria of effect-hood must both appear.
- Distinction: nimitta-kāraṇa versus upādāna-kāraṇa; explanatory versus temporal priority.
- Technical terms: kāryāt, āyojanāt, dhṛtyādeḥ, padāt, śruteḥ, adṛṣṭa, karmaphaladātā, praeambula fidei.
- Comparison: the Janet–Lotze–Martineau parallel, plus the observation that Western theists make God the source of existence and Nyāya only of order.
- Criticism: Hume's analogy objection on Nyāya; the redundancy objection; Kant's ontological-borrowing charge on Aquinas.
- Conclusion: same architecture, different terminus — stated as a criterion-named judgement.

Compact skeleton and timing

2 min : Comparative frame – two a posteriori natural theologies
 4 min : Five Ways, with the per se series and "first = explanatory"
 5 min : Nyaya routes with Sanskrit terms and the omniscience step
 3 min : Convergence – inference from order; cumulative structure
 4 min : Divergence – material causation, scripture, moral constraint
 2 min : Differential critique – Hume on Nyaya; redundancy; Kant on Aquinas
 1 min : Criterion-named verdict
 Total : 21 minutes

Common mistakes and examiner penalties

- Writing Aquinas for ten minutes and Nyāya for ten with no comparison: the directive is unanswered; heavy loss.
- Calling Nyāya's God the material cause: the topic's most penalised factual error.
- Reducing the Five Ways to "first cause": collapses four distinct arguments.

- Omitting Sanskrit terminology: loses the Optional's technical premium.
- Claiming Nyāya is "the Indian Aquinas" without qualification: false equivalence.
- Ending with "both are similar": an ungraded conclusion earns no evaluative marks.

PYQ 3 — 2018, Q8(b), 15 marks

Exact question

"Critically evaluate the Buddhistic arguments against the existence of God as the creator of the world."

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	Critically evaluate — state the arguments, then judge their force, including where they fail
Core issue	Whether conditioned arising renders a creator explanatorily and morally unnecessary
Scope boundary	The target is jagat-kartā, a world-maker; Buddhism's rejection of the sacred is not at issue
Ideal thesis	The arguments are decisive against an anthropomorphic purposive world-maker, weaker against a metaphysically refined classical theism
Non-negotiables	At least four canonical lines, plus the theistic replies

Model answer (≈245 words)

Buddhism rejects a creator God (jagat-kartā) without rejecting spiritual ultimacy; its critique is a systematic refusal of explanatory surplus rather than bare atheism.

Four canonical lines recur. First, if God is eternal and unchanging, genuine creation is hard to explain, since willing or producing appears to involve change; Dharmakīrti-type reasoning sharpens this — a permanent, immutable cause fully present at all times should produce its effect always and at once, never in temporal succession. Second, if God creates from desire or purpose, this implies lack, preference or incompleteness, which is inconsistent with perfection. Third, suffering and evil sit uneasily with an omnipotent benevolent creator. Fourth, dependent origination already explains the arising of phenomena through conditions, so a creator is redundant. To these may be added the methodological point that questions of a first beginning fall among the avyākṛta, undeclared because soteriologically idle — the wounded man who insists on knowing the archer before the arrow is removed.

Evaluation must be even-handed. The change objection assumes a temporal model of divine willing; classical theism answers with a single eternal act producing a temporal effect. The desire objection assumes creation must remedy a lack; theists appeal to gratuitous diffusive goodness. Most importantly, Nyāya replies that dependent origination explains sequence but not desert-appropriate allocation: an unconscious nexus cannot proportion determinate fruit to determinate merit. Explanatory economy, moreover, is a methodological preference, not a disproof.

Verdict: Buddhism establishes that a coherent, ethically serious cosmology is possible without a creator. That is a substantial philosophical achievement — but it shifts the burden of proof rather than closing the question.

What a top Philosophy Optional answer must contain

- Structure: clarify the target → four to six arguments as reconstructions → theistic replies → graded verdict.
- Doctrine: pratītyasamutpāda; the avyākṛta questions; anti-Īśvara argumentation in Dharmakīrti and Śāntarākṣita.
- Argument: the immutability–succession incompatibility must be stated as an argument, not as an assertion.
- Distinction: rejecting a creator ≠ atheism in the Western sense; nāstika = denier of Vedic authority.
- Technical terms: jagat-kartā, pratītyasamutpāda, avyākṛta, explanatory parsimony.

- Comparison: one line linking Buddhist economy to Hume's Epicurean hypothesis and Darwinian sufficiency.
- Criticism: the Nyāya allocation reply is the strongest counter and must appear.
- Conclusion: decisive against a purposive anthropomorphic maker; inconclusive against refined theism.

Compact skeleton and timing

1 min : Clarify the target – jagat-karta, not the sacred
 6 min : Immutability/succession · desire implies lack · evil ·
 dependent origination · avyakṛta silence · freedom-karma dilemma
 4 min : Replies – eternal act, diffusive goodness, Nyaya on allocation,
 economy is methodological
 2 min : Note that nastika means denial of Vedic authority
 1 min : Graded verdict
 Total : 14 minutes

Common mistakes and examiner penalties

- Treating the arguments as a proof of atheism: misstates their logical status.
- Writing a devotional account of the Buddha instead of arguments: no philosophical content.
- Omitting the replies in a "critically evaluate" question: the directive is half-answered.
- Calling Buddhism nāstika in the sense of "spiritually nihilistic": terminological error.
- Confusing the Buddhist argument from evil with the full problem of evil: scope drift.
- Ending with "hence God does not exist": unwarranted and penalised.

PYQ 4 — 2019, Q5(e), 10 marks

Exact question

"State and evaluate the proofs for the existence of God as propounded in Jainism."

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	State and evaluate — exposition plus judgement, in 150 words
Core issue	In what sense Jainism has a God at all, and what it proves about that God
Scope boundary	Do not write a general essay on Jaina metaphysics
Ideal thesis	Jainism denies God as creator but affirms godhead; its proofs establish attainable perfection, not a cosmic maker
Non-negotiables	The denial/affirmation disambiguation; at least two positive proofs; one evaluative limit

Model answer (≈160 words)

Jainism denies God as creator: the world was never created, since all substances are eternal and change only through modes (utpāda–vyaya–dhrauvya). But "Jainism denies God, and yet does not deny godhead. Every liberated soul is a god."

Its proofs are accordingly proofs of attainable divinity. First, from the intrinsic nature of the jīva: every soul possesses infinite knowledge, perception, bliss and power (ananta-catuṣṭaya), obscured by material karma rather than absent — for we observe degrees of knowledge, not its absence. Second, from gradation to a limiting case: mati, śruta, avadhi and manaḥparyāya mark progressive removal of karmic obstruction, whose complete removal is kevala-jñāna, omniscience. Third, from the testimony of the omniscient Tīrthaṅkaras (āpta-vacana), mortals who won liberation by personal effort — "we are all potential Jinās".

Evaluation: these establish a plural, achieved, non-creative godhood and rest wholly on Jaina premises — intrinsic omniscience and material karma. They neither prove nor attempt a cosmic God. Sharma's dilemma bites: if karma is inseparable from the soul, liberation is impossible; if separable, bondage is.

What a top Philosophy Optional answer must contain

- Structure: disambiguate "God" → three proofs → one internal criticism → verdict, all within 150 words.
- Doctrine: ananta-catuṣṭaya; the five knowledges; kevala-jñāna; siddha and Tīrthaṅkara.
- Argument: the gradation-to-limiting-case inference must be visible as an inference.
- Distinction: God as world-maker versus God as perfected being; Jaina karma is material (pudgala), not adṛṣṭa.
- Technical terms: utpāda-vyaya-dhrauvya, āpta-vacana, tri-ratna, nāstika correctly glossed.
- Comparison: one clause contrasting this with Nyāya's efficient-cause creator.
- Criticism: the bondage/liberation dilemma, or the internality of the premises.
- Conclusion: a soteriological rather than cosmological theism.

Compact skeleton and timing

1 min : Denies creator, affirms godhead – the controlling distinction
 4 min : Three proofs, compressed but as arguments
 2 min : Evaluation – premises internal to Jaina metaphysics; Sharma's dilemma
 1 min : Verdict – soteriological, not cosmological, theism
 Total : 8 minutes

Common mistakes and examiner penalties

- Writing "Jainism is atheistic, so there are no proofs": misreads the question and forfeits most marks.
- Substituting a general account of anekāntavāda or the tri-ratna: off-question.
- Equating Jaina karma with Nyāya's adṛṣṭa: doctrinal error.
- Calling the siddha a creator or governor: contradicts the doctrine.
- Exceeding the word limit at the cost of the evaluation: the second directive verb is lost.

PYQ 5 — 2020, Q6(a), 20 marks

Exact question

"Is the ontological proof for the existence of God by St. Anselm logical? Discuss."

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	Discuss an evaluative question — you must take a position on logicity, not merely on truth
Core issue	Whether the argument is formally valid, and whether its validity is purchased by an illegitimate use of "exists"
Scope boundary	Anselm centrally; Descartes and modal versions only as extensions
Ideal thesis	The argument is formally coherent as a reductio, but it is not logically compelling, because its crucial premise misclassifies existence
Non-negotiables	Both forms; the validity/soundness distinction; Gaunilo; Kant; a stated verdict

Model answer (~350 words)

Whether Anselm's proof is "logical" must be split into two questions: is it valid, and is its key premise legitimate?

Anselm's Proslogion 2 argument is a reductio. Suppose that than which nothing greater can be conceived exists in the understanding alone. Existing in reality is greater than existing in the understanding alone. Then a greater than the greatest conceivable could be conceived — a contradiction. Therefore it exists in reality. Formally this is impeccable: given the definition and the comparative premise, the conclusion follows. Proslogion 3 strengthens it: a being that cannot be thought not to exist is greater than one that can, so God exists necessarily; since God as infinitely perfect is not limited by time, both coming-to-be and ceasing-to-be are excluded.

The difficulty is not the inference but the comparative premise. Gaunilo, in *In Behalf of the Fool*, constructs a parallel for the most perfect conceivable island; if the form is valid, it manufactures islands. Anselm replies that only God is defined as having eternal and independent existence, whereas an island — a piece of land surrounded by water — is by definition contingent and can without contradiction be thought not to exist. The reply succeeds for the second form, but it transfers the burden: it must now be shown that maximal greatness is a coherent notion with an intrinsic maximum, whereas island-perfections plainly are not.

Kant supplies the decisive diagnosis. Existence is not a real predicate: it adds nothing to a concept but posits its object. A hundred real thalers contain no more concept than a hundred possible ones. If so, "existing in reality is greater" is not a legitimate comparison of concepts at all, and the argument is valid only in the trivial sense that it correctly draws out what was illicitly built in. Modern quantificational analysis reinforces this by treating existence as second-order.

Modal reconstructions by Malcolm, Hartshorne and Plantinga preserve necessary existence and are formally valid in S5; but their possibility premise — that a maximally great being is possible — is precisely what is disputed, and a symmetrical possibility-of-non-existence yields the opposite conclusion.

Verdict: Anselm's proof is logically well-formed but not logically compelling. It is valid in form, question-begging in premise, and at best establishes a conditional: if a maximally great being is possible, it exists necessarily.

What a top Philosophy Optional answer must contain

- Structure: split "logical" into validity and legitimacy → both forms → Gaunilo → Kant → modal → explicit verdict.
- Doctrine: the reductio structure; aseity; necessary existence.
- Argument: the comparative premise must be isolated as the load-bearing step.
- Distinction: validity versus soundness; a well-formed argument versus a compelling one.
- Technical terms: real predicate, determining predicate, S5, possibility premise, second-order quantification.
- Comparison: one line noting Chatterjee–Datta's parallel hundred-rupees formulation in the Indian tradition.
- Criticism: Gaunilo attacks the form's generality; Kant attacks the concept of existence. Both are needed.
- Conclusion: an explicit, defended answer to "is it logical?" — hedging is penalised here more than anywhere else in this topic.

Compact skeleton and timing

2 min : Split the question – valid? legitimate premise?
 5 min : Proslogion 2 as a reductio; Proslogion 3 and necessary existence
 4 min : Gaunilo, Anselm's reply, and the transferred burden
 5 min : Kant's diagnosis; the quantificational reinforcement
 3 min : Modal versions and the possibility premise
 2 min : Explicit verdict – well-formed, not compelling
 Total : 21 minutes

Common mistakes and examiner penalties

- Answering "no, because God cannot be proved": does not engage logicity at all.
- Treating validity and soundness as one thing: the question's whole hinge is missed.
- Omitting Proslogion 3: Anselm's reply to Gaunilo becomes unintelligible.
- Presenting Kant's objection as "Kant said God does not exist": serious misattribution.
- Refusing to give a verdict: "Discuss" with an evaluative stem requires a position.

PYQ 6 — 2021, Q7(b), 15 marks

Exact question

"Give a critical account of moral argument to prove the existence of God."

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	Critical account — full exposition plus sustained criticism
Core issue	Whether moral experience can establish, or rationally require, belief in God
Scope boundary	Both forms of the moral argument; the other proofs only as contrast
Ideal thesis	The inferential form begs the question; Kant's postulational form is defensible but is not a proof
Non-negotiables	Kant's three postulates; the highest good; "ought implies can"; Euthyphro correctly aimed

Model answer (~250 words)

The moral argument claims that ethical experience presupposes the reality of God. It takes two very different forms.

The first form is a straightforward inference: from objective moral laws to a divine Law Giver, or from conscience to a God whose voice it is. Newman's Grammar of Assent argues that feeling shame and fear before conscience implies One before whom we are ashamed. The objection is fatal: this assumes that moral values admit of no naturalistic explanation in terms of human needs, social structure or practical reason. That assumption is precisely what is in dispute, so the argument begs the question.

The second form, Kant's, is not strictly a proof. Having demolished the speculative proofs in the Critique of Pure Reason — the ontological by denying that existence is a real predicate, the cosmological by showing it borrows the ontological — Kant reinstates God in the Critique of Practical Reason. The moral law obligates us to promote the highest good, virtue together with proportionate happiness. "Ought implies can" requires that the highest good be really possible. But holiness is unattainable in finite time, and nature does not proportion happiness to desert. Hence three postulates of practical reason: freedom, immortality and God — objects of rational faith, practically necessary and theoretically undemonstrable.

Criticism cuts several ways. The postulate may be a projection of a desire for cosmic fairness, though Kant answers that it arises from the structure of moral reason, not from reward-seeking, which would be heteronomy. If morality is autonomous, God's role is confined to realisability, not obligation — which also insulates Kant from the Euthyphro dilemma, whose real target is divine-command theory. Adequacy remains the deepest problem: as Hick notes, moral values cannot be said to point all the way to the infinite, self-existent personal creator.

Verdict: as a proof it fails, and Kant never offered it as one; as an account of what moral seriousness rationally presupposes, it retains genuine force. Nyāya's karmaphaladātā addresses the same problem but claims knowledge where Kant claims only hope.

What a top Philosophy Optional answer must contain

- Structure: two forms distinguished → Kant's derivation as steps → four to five criticisms → graded verdict.
- Doctrine: summum bonum; the three postulates; Vernunftglaube; autonomy.
- Argument: "ought implies can" must be shown doing work, not merely quoted.
- Distinction: postulate versus demonstration versus empirical hypothesis.
- Technical terms: heteronomy, practical reason, fact of reason, Euthyphro.

- Comparison: the Nyāya karmaphaladātā parallel, with the epistemic contrast.
- Criticism: projection, autonomy tension, adequacy; and Euthyphro aimed at divine-command theory, not Kant.
- Conclusion: it establishes a rational hope, not a demonstrated being.

Compact skeleton and timing

1 min : Two forms flagged at once
 2 min : Newman's inferential form and the question-begging objection
 5 min : Kant – CPR demolition, then the highest good and three postulates
 4 min : Criticism – projection, autonomy, Euthyphro's real target, adequacy
 2 min : Nyaya comparison
 1 min : Graded verdict
 Total : 15 minutes

Common mistakes and examiner penalties

- Writing "Kant proves God through morality": the single most penalised error in this topic.
- Listing only one postulate: loses the systematic structure.
- Aiming Euthyphro at Kant: misapplied objection.
- Treating the postulate as a reward-motive: contradicts Kant's own doctrine of autonomy.
- Omitting the first form entirely: "critical account" of the moral argument requires both.
- Omitting any Indian comparison in a Paper II answer: loses the comparative premium.

PYQ 7 — 2022, Q6(a), 20 marks

Exact question

"Present a critical exposition of different arguments offered by St. Thomas Aquinas to prove the existence of God also known as 'Five Ways'. Which one of them do you find philosophically most interesting? Give reasons in support of your answer."

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	Two directives: critical exposition of all five, and a defended personal judgement
Core issue	Whether the Ways are distinct arguments, and which best withstands scrutiny
Scope boundary	All five must appear; the chosen Way must then be developed further
Ideal thesis	The Ways are five distinct arguments; Way 3 (or Way 5) is most interesting, for stated philosophical reasons
Non-negotiables	The per se / per accidens distinction; "first" as explanatory; a reasoned choice with objections handled

Model answer (~350 words)

Aquinas' Five Ways (ST I, q.2, a.3) are five distinct a posteriori arguments, not one argument restated. Each begins from a general feature of the world and concludes with the cautious formula "and this everyone understands to be God" — itself an admission that further work is needed to identify the terminus with the God of religion.

Way 1 argues from motion, understood as the reduction of potentiality to actuality: whatever is moved is moved by another, and an essentially ordered series of movers cannot regress infinitely, so there is an unmoved mover. Way 2 argues from an order of efficient causes to a first efficient cause. Way 3 argues from contingency: if everything were

merely possible, at some time nothing would have existed, and nothing would exist now; hence there is a necessary being, and ultimately one necessary of itself. Way 4 argues from degrees of goodness and truth to a maximum which causes all perfection. Way 5 argues from the regular goal-directed activity of things lacking cognition to a directing intelligence, as the arrow is directed by the archer.

Critically, the excluded regress is essentially ordered — the stick moves the stone only while the hand moves the stick — so "first" denotes explanatory priority, not chronological firstness. Aquinas himself concedes the difficulty of excluding an endless series of events, and holds that the world's temporal beginning is known by faith, not demonstration; neo-Thomists accordingly recast the excluded series as simultaneous dependence. Way 3 is vulnerable to a quantifier shift at the step from "each thing at some time is not" to "at some time nothing is". Way 4 requires the Platonic machinery of participation, since degrees of heat do not entail a hottest object. Way 5 is exposed to Hume's analogy objection and, in Paley's later form, to Darwin. Kant's overarching charge is that the passage from "a necessary being" to "the most real being" is the ontological argument in disguise.

Most interesting: Way 3. It alone poses the deepest question — why is there anything at all rather than nothing? — and it is the only Way whose central premise, the Principle of Sufficient Reason, remains a live philosophical dispute against brute-fact naturalism. Its conclusion is also modally strongest: not merely a first mover but a being whose non-existence is impossible. That it is simultaneously the most vulnerable, at the quantifier-shift step, makes it philosophically the richest rather than the weakest — a bad argument for the best question is more instructive than a safe argument for a smaller one.

What a top Philosophy Optional answer must contain

- Structure: all five expounded compactly → critical apparatus → a defended choice with its own objection answered.
- Doctrine: act and potency; per se causal series; contingency and necessity; participation.
- Argument: each Way in one or two premise-steps, never as a bare label.
- Distinction: explanatory versus temporal priority; Way 2 (causal dependence) versus Way 3 (modal status).
- Technical terms: per se / per accidens, PSR, ab alio / a se, quantifier shift.
- Comparison: one line on Nyāya's parallel cumulative structure, or on the Kalām's contrasting temporal claim.
- Criticism: Hume, Kant and one internal weakness per Way where space allows.
- Conclusion: the personal judgement must be argued, with a criterion named — depth of question, modal strength, or contemporary liveness.

Compact skeleton and timing

2 min : Frame – five distinct a posteriori arguments
 7 min : Ways 1-5, each as premises
 5 min : Critical apparatus – per se series, Aquinas on eternity, quantifier shift, participation, Hume/Darwin, Kant
 5 min : The chosen Way, defended, with one objection met
 2 min : Conclusion naming the criterion of choice
 Total : 21 minutes

Common mistakes and examiner penalties

- Presenting the Ways as one "first cause" argument: destroys the exposition mark.
- Choosing a Way but giving no philosophical reasons: the second directive is unanswered.
- Choosing Way 2 and glossing it as "God started the universe": misrepresents Aquinas.
- Introducing Paley's watch as Aquinas': factual error.
- Asserting that Aquinas proves a temporal beginning: contradicts ST I q.46 a.2.
- Omitting all criticism in a "critical exposition": half the directive lost.

PYQ 8 — 2022, Q8(a), 20 marks

Exact question

"Discuss the main points of distinction between a priori and a posteriori arguments for the existence of God. Which one according to you should be preferred over the other? Give reasons and justifications for your answer."

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	Discuss the distinction, and defend a preference with reasons
Core issue	The trade-off between modal strength and evidential contact
Scope boundary	Use exemplars from both families, Indian and Western; do not merely define
Ideal thesis	A criterion-relative preference: a posteriori for evidential respectability, a priori for modal strength, neither for religious adequacy
Non-negotiables	A multi-axis distinction table in prose; at least three exemplars; an explicit preference

Model answer (~345 words)

The distinction is not merely one of subject matter but of evidential source, method, modal outcome and characteristic vulnerability.

An a priori argument reasons from the concept of God alone, without empirical premises. The ontological argument is the sole classical instance: Anselm derives existence, and then necessary existence, from the concept of that than which nothing greater can be conceived; Descartes derives it from the essence of a supremely perfect being. Its method is conceptual analysis, and its promised reward is enormous — if it works, it yields a necessary God, immune to empirical revision.

An a posteriori argument reasons from some general feature of the world. Aquinas' Ways begin from motion, causation, contingency, degrees and purposive order; Paley begins from means–end adjustment; Kant's moral argument begins from the structure of moral obligation; and Nyāya's Īśvara-anumāna begins from the world as a composite effect requiring an omniscient intelligent maker. Their method is inference from effect to cause, or inference to the best explanation, and their conclusions are correspondingly probable rather than necessary.

Their vulnerabilities differ accordingly. The a priori route faces Kant's charge that existence is not a real predicate, and Gaunilo's demonstration that the form proves too much; modal repairs shift the burden to an unestablished possibility premise. The a posteriori route faces Hume: the world–artefact analogy is weak, and from a finite effect one may infer only a finite cause. It is also exposed to scientific advance — Darwin against Paley, cosmological alternatives against the Kalām — whereas the a priori route is immune to empirical developments precisely because it is empirically empty.

Preference. I prefer the a posteriori route, on three grounds. First, dialectical: it begins from premises the opponent already grants — that things change, that order exists, that we are obligated — whereas the a priori route asks the opponent to grant a contested concept. Second, epistemic: it does not require the illegitimate treatment of existence as a determining predicate. Third, traditional convergence: two independent civilisations, Thomist Europe and Nyāya India, arrived at structurally similar a posteriori arguments, which suggests the route tracks something real in the explanatory demand.

But the preference must be graded. The price is that a posteriori arguments deliver at most a probable, possibly finite cause, and never the God of developed religion. If the criterion were modal strength rather than evidential contact, the ranking would reverse. Neither route alone secures religious adequacy — which is why every tradition eventually supplements proof with experience, testimony or faith.

What a top Philosophy Optional answer must contain

- Structure: multi-axis distinction → exemplars on both sides → differential vulnerabilities → a preference with three named reasons → a graded qualification.
- Doctrine: ontological versus cosmological/teleological/moral/Nyāya families.

- Argument: the trade-off between modal strength and evidential contact must be made explicit.
- Distinction: conceptual entailment versus inference to a cause; necessity versus probability.
- Technical terms: real predicate, vyāpti, inference to the best explanation, underdetermination.
- Comparison: Nyāya must appear as an a posteriori exemplar — this is a Paper II answer.
- Criticism: Kant and Gaunilo on one side; Hume and Darwin on the other.
- Conclusion: criterion-relative preference, explicitly named, never a bare "both are useful".

Compact skeleton and timing

3 min : Four axes of distinction – source, method, modality, vulnerability
 5 min : A priori exemplars – Anselm, Descartes, and the modal repair
 5 min : A posteriori exemplars – Ways, Paley, Kant, Nyaya
 3 min : Differential vulnerabilities
 4 min : Preference with three reasons
 1 min : Graded qualification naming the alternative criterion
 Total : 21 minutes

Common mistakes and examiner penalties

- Defining the terms and stopping: the second directive is ignored.
- Equating a priori with "certain" and a posteriori with "uncertain": conceptual error.
- Omitting Nyāya: a Paper II answer with no Indian material is under-marked.
- Preferring one without naming a criterion: an unjustified preference.
- Claiming a priori arguments are Western and a posteriori Indian: historically false.
- Concluding "both are equally good": fails the explicit demand for a preference.

PYQ 9 — 2023, Q7(a), 20 marks

Exact question

"Critically examine the arguments of Nyāya for the existence of God."

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	Critically examine — full reconstruction, then rigorous evaluation
Core issue	Whether Nyāya's inferences establish an omniscient efficient cause
Scope boundary	The arguments, though a brief statement of the nature of Īśvara is needed to make them intelligible
Ideal thesis	Individually inconclusive and jointly cumulative; the redundancy objection is the deepest threat
Non-negotiables	Four to five arguments in Sanskrit; the efficient/material cause thesis; Indian critics before Western ones

Model answer (≈350 words)

Nyāya offers a rational, inferential theism. Īśvara is an eternal, omniscient special self, the first efficient cause — a demiurgus or builder of the ordered universe — not its material cause; He is also preserver and destroyer, which distinguishes Nyāya theism from deism.

Kāryāt — the causal argument. All composite objects of the world are effects, since they are made of parts (sāvayava) and possess intermediate magnitude (avāntara-mahattva); space, time, ether and self are excluded as partless

infinities, and atoms and manas as simple infinitesimals. Material causes alone cannot attain the order, direction and co-ordination that produce such effects. The intelligent cause must therefore have direct knowledge of the atoms, a desire for an end, and the will to realise it — and must be omniscient, since only an omniscient being can directly know entities so simple and infinitesimal as atoms.

Āyojanāt — inert atoms cannot combine purposively of themselves. Dhṛtyādeḥ — the world's support, maintenance and dissolution require governance. Padāt / āptaprāmāṇya — the Veda's authority derives from an omniscient author, as a science's authority derives from its founder; the jīva cannot be that author, since supramundane realities exceed ordinary cognition. Śruteḥ — scripture directly testifies to God. Finally, the argument from adrṣṭa: differences of lot require causes; karma supplies them; but the time-gap requires a persisting stock of merit and demerit; and adrṣṭa, being unintelligent, cannot allot precisely the joy and sorrow deserved, while individual selves neither know nor control it. Hence God is karmaphaladātā.

Critically: the circularity charge against the last two arguments is answered by distinguishing the order of existence (God creates the Veda) from the order of knowledge (the Veda discloses God); the bodiless-agent objection is met by a dilemma. But the deeper objections stand. Mīmāṃsā holds the Veda apauruṣeya and apūrva self-maturing, which dissolves two arguments at once. Buddhism and Jainism hold that conditions and material karma suffice. Cārvāka denies inference's reach. Śāṅkara presses a dilemma on whether atoms are active or inactive, and treats Nyāya's God as merely saguṇa. C. D. Sharma's redundancy objection is sharpest: this God is "reduced to the status of a supervisor", His hands and feet "chained by the shackles of the Law of Karma unfolding itself as the Adrṣṭa".

Verdict: the arguments are individually inconclusive but cumulatively serious, in Udayana's manner. They share the limits of all a posteriori theism — Chatterjee and Datta themselves conclude, with Kant and Lotze, that God cannot be deduced from anterior premises and must be known through direct experience.

What a top Philosophy Optional answer must contain

- Structure: nature of Īśvara in two lines → four to five arguments as reconstructions → internal replies → external critiques → graded verdict.
- Doctrine: efficient not material cause; ṣaḍ-aiśvarya; prayojaka kartā; karmaphaladātā.
- Argument: the sāvayava / avāntara-mahattva criteria and the derivation of omniscience must both be present.
- Distinction: order of existence versus order of knowledge; theism versus deism.
- Technical terms: kāryāt, āyojanāt, dhṛtyādeḥ, padāt, śruteḥ, adrṣṭa, apauruṣeya, apūrva, saguṇa.
- Comparison: Janet, Lotze and Martineau as parallels — with the divergence over existence versus order.
- Criticism: Indian critics first (Mīmāṃsā, Buddhist, Jaina, Cārvāka, Advaita), then the redundancy objection.
- Conclusion: cumulative but not demonstrative; note the textbook tradition's own experiential turn.

Compact skeleton and timing

2 min : Isvara – efficient cause, preserver, destroyer; theism not deism
 7 min : Karyat (with omniscience derivation), ayojanat, dhṛtyadeh, padat/sruteh, adrsta
 4 min : Internal replies – circularity, bodiless agent
 5 min : External critiques – Mimamsa, Buddha, Jaina, Carvaka, Sankara, Sharma's redundancy
 3 min : Graded verdict + Chatterjee-Datta's experiential conclusion
 Total : 21 minutes

Common mistakes and examiner penalties

- Calling God the material cause: the single worst error available here.
- Listing the proofs without reconstructing any: descriptive, not analytical.
- Using only Hume and Kant as critics: ignores the Indian debate the question presupposes.
- Conceding the Veda–God circularity: the classical reply exists and should be given.
- Confusing adrṣṭa with Jaina material karma: doctrinal error.
- Concluding "hence Nyāya proves God": ungraded and indefensible.

PYQ 10 — 2024, Q7(c), 15 marks (10 + 5)

Exact question

"Present an exposition of ontological proof for the existence of God along with its criticism."

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	Explicitly split: 10 marks exposition + 5 marks criticism
Core issue	Faithful reconstruction, then targeted objection
Scope boundary	Allocate roughly two-thirds of the space to exposition
Ideal thesis	A clear reconstruction of both Anselmian forms and Descartes, criticised through Gaunilo and Kant
Non-negotiables	The mark split must be visibly respected in the answer's proportions

Model answer (~250 words)

Exposition (10). The ontological proof is the sole classical a priori argument: it moves from the concept of God to God's existence without any empirical premise. Anselm defines God as "that than which nothing greater can be conceived", where "greater" means more perfect — and deliberately not as "the most perfect being that there is", which would guarantee nothing. In Proslogion 2 he argues by reductio: even the fool who denies God understands the concept; but if this being existed in the understanding alone, we could conceive a greater — the same being existing in reality as well — which contradicts the definition; therefore it exists in reality. In Proslogion 3 he strengthens the conclusion: a being that cannot be thought not to exist is greater than one that can; and since God as infinitely perfect is not limited by time, both coming-to-be and ceasing-to-be are excluded. God therefore exists necessarily, by aseity. Descartes reformulates it in Meditations V: existence belongs to the essence of a supremely perfect being as three angles belong to a triangle, or a valley to a mountain; a perfect being lacking existence would lack a perfection.

Criticism (5). Gaunilo, in In Behalf of the Fool, parodies the form with the most perfect conceivable island; Anselm replies that only God is defined with necessary existence, an island being by definition contingent — but the reply then requires that maximal greatness be coherent. Kant's objection is decisive: existence is not a real predicate; a hundred real thalers add no concept to a hundred possible ones. Modal repairs preserve validity but relocate the burden onto an unestablished possibility premise.

What a top Philosophy Optional answer must contain

- Structure: the 10 + 5 split must be visible, ideally with the exposition twice the length of the criticism.
- Doctrine: both Anselmian forms plus Descartes; the fool; aseity.
- Argument: the reductio reproduced as steps.
- Distinction: "greatest conceivable" versus "greatest that there is" — a mark-winning nuance.
- Technical terms: real predicate, necessary existence, possibility premise.
- Comparison: optional single line that Indian philosophy has no a priori analogue.
- Criticism: Gaunilo on form, Kant on the concept of existence — both, in that order.
- Conclusion: state what survives: a conditional, not an instantiation.

Compact skeleton and timing

1 min : A priori status and Anselm's definition, precisely worded
 5 min : Proslogion 2, then Proslogion 3; then Descartes
 1 min : Note the "conceivable" vs "that there is" nuance
 4 min : Gaunilo + reply; Kant; modal burden
 1 min : What survives — a conditional
 Total : 12 minutes

Common mistakes and examiner penalties

- Ignoring the 10 + 5 split and writing a balanced essay: structural penalty.
- Giving criticism first: inverts the stated weighting.
- Reproducing only Descartes: the question says "ontological proof", whose primary text is Anselm.
- Confusing Gaunilo's and Kant's objections: factual error.
- Omitting Proslogion 3: the reply to Gaunilo cannot then be stated.

PYQ 11 — 2025, Q6(a), 20 marks

Exact question

"Present an account of Design argument to prove the existence of God along with its criticism by David Hume."

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	Exposition plus a named critic — Hume specifically, not general criticism
Core issue	Whether order and adaptation license an inference to an intelligent, single, infinite, good designer
Scope boundary	Hume must dominate the critical half; Darwin and fine-tuning are extensions, not substitutes
Ideal thesis	Hume defeats the argument as a demonstration and blocks the passage to the God of theism, without disproving a designer
Non-negotiables	Aquinas' Way 5 distinguished from Paley; Paley's three riders; at least four Hume fronts; the 1779/1802 chronology

Model answer (≈355 words)

The design or teleological argument runs from Plato's *Timaeus* through Aquinas to the modern period. Two forms must be distinguished. Aquinas' Fifth Way argues that things lacking cognition act for an end, and do so always or nearly always in the same way; such directedness cannot be chance, so they are directed by an intelligent being, as the arrow by the archer. Paley's argument, in *Natural Theology* (1802), is instead an analogy: finding a watch on a heath, with wheels, cogs, springs and balances all working together to measure time, I cannot attribute it to wind and rain as I could a stone; I must postulate an intelligent maker. Paley adds three riders — the inference survives never having seen a watch made, imperfect working, and parts whose function we cannot discover — and then builds a long cumulative case from the eye, the bird's wing, the fish's fin, planetary motion and the seasons.

Hume's critique, in the *Dialogues Concerning Natural Religion*, was published in 1779, twenty-three years before Paley, who took no apparent account of it. It attacks on five fronts. First, any universe capable of persisting must display mutual adaptation — there could not be birds with wings unable to live in air — so adaptation is a precondition of order, not evidence of design; Hume offers the Epicurean hypothesis, that a finite number of particles in random motion will in unlimited time pass through every combination, one of which is a stable order. Second, the analogy is weak: the universe resembles a vegetable or a crustacean as much as a machine, and whether those are designed is the very question at issue. Third, cause must be proportioned to effect: from a finite world one may infer only a finite cause — his illustration of the scales, where an unseen weight can be inferred to exceed ten ounces but never to be infinite. Fourth, the evidence equally supports many designers, an inferior one, an infant or senile deity, or an abandoned first attempt. Fifth, evil and disorder count against a good and powerful designer.

Darwin later supplies a mechanism that removes Paley's biological premise; Hick's ozone example inverts the intuition, since life fitted itself to the filter rather than the filter to life. Modern fine-tuning arguments relocate design to pre-biological constants, answering Hume's first two fronts while remaining fully exposed to the last three, and facing multiverse rivals.

Verdict: Hume does not disprove a designer — Philo himself concedes a remote analogy — but he destroys the argument's demonstrative pretension and blocks the passage from an orderer to the one, infinite, perfectly good God of theism. Design survives only as an inference to the best explanation.

What a top Philosophy Optional answer must contain

- Structure: distinguish the two forms → Paley in full → Hume's five fronts → Darwin and fine-tuning → graded verdict.
- Doctrine: Way 5's archer–arrow; Paley's watch and three riders.
- Argument: the analogy must be displayed as an analogy, with its two relata named.
- Distinction: Aquinas ≠ Paley ≠ fine-tuning; and evidential objections (fronts 1–2) versus adequacy objections (fronts 3–5).
- Technical terms: Epicurean hypothesis, proportioning cause to effect, means–end adjustment, anthropic selection.
- Comparison: Nyāya's āyojanāt and the pot–potter model as the Indian analogue.
- Criticism: Hume must be given in his own examples, not paraphrased generically.
- Conclusion: demonstrative failure plus surviving explanatory force, stated as a graded verdict.

Compact skeleton and timing

2 min : Two forms distinguished – Way 5 vs Paley
 5 min : Paley – the watch, three riders, cumulative evidence
 7 min : Hume's five fronts with his own illustrations; note 1779 vs 1802
 3 min : Darwin (ozone) and fine-tuning; exact scope of each
 2 min : Nyaya's ayojanat as Indian analogue
 2 min : Graded verdict – inference to the best explanation
 Total : 21 minutes

Common mistakes and examiner penalties

- Attributing the watch to Aquinas: factual error, and it wastes the best distinction available.
- Writing "Hume disproved the design argument": misstates his conclusion.
- Giving only two Hume objections in a 20-marker: thin criticism.
- Letting Darwin displace Hume: the question names Hume.
- Treating fine-tuning as the same argument as Paley's: category error.
- Omitting the Indian analogue in Paper II: loses comparative credit.

PYQ 12 — 2025, Q7(b), 15 marks

Exact question

"What proofs do Nyāya philosophers offer for the existence of God? Discuss."

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	What proofs... Discuss — exposition-weighted, with evaluation attached
Core issue	The content and structure of the Nyāya proof-set
Scope boundary	Narrower than 2023's "critically examine": more exposition, less polemic
Ideal thesis	A structured set of mutually reinforcing inferences to an omniscient efficient cause, cumulatively rather than individually persuasive

Element	Requirement
Non-negotiables	Sanskrit terminology; the efficient-cause thesis; a note that enumerations vary; a short evaluation

Model answer (~250 words)

Nyāya offers not one proof but an array — the tradition claims as many as ten, though enumerations vary across texts and summaries, so an answer should present the principal ones and say so.

Kāryāt, the causal argument, is central. All composite objects — mountains, seas, sun and moon — are effects, since they are made of parts (sāvaṃyava) and possess intermediate magnitude (avāntara-mahattva). Space, time, ether and self are excluded as partless infinities; atoms and manas as simple infinitesimals. Material causes cannot by themselves attain the order and co-ordination required to produce such effects, so an intelligent maker is needed, possessing direct knowledge of the atoms, a desire for an end, and the will to realise it. He must be omniscient, since only an omniscient being can directly know entities so simple and infinitesimal as atoms.

Āyojanāt: inert atoms require purposive combination. Dhṛtyādeḥ: the world's support, maintenance and destruction imply governance. Padāt / āptaprāmānya: the Veda's authority presupposes an omniscient trustworthy author, since no jīva can know supramundane realities. Śruteḥ: scripture testifies directly. The argument from adrṣṭa completes the set: the unconscious stock of merit and demerit cannot itself allot the precise joy and sorrow deserved, nor do selves know or control it; hence God is karmaphaladātā, the impartial dispenser.

Throughout, Īśvara is the efficient, not material, cause: atoms are eternal, and God orders rather than produces them; He also preserves and destroys, which makes Nyāya theistic rather than deistic.

Discussion: the proofs are mutually reinforcing in Udayana's cumulative manner, but each is contested — Mīmāṃsā by apauruṣeya and apūrva, Buddhism and Jainism by karmic sufficiency, Cārvāka by restricting pramāṇas. They establish a probable cosmic administrator rather than a demonstrated absolute.

What a top Philosophy Optional answer must contain

- Structure: note the plurality of proofs → present five or six with Sanskrit names → state the efficient-cause thesis → short evaluation.
- Doctrine: sāvaṃyava, avāntara-mahattva, the omniscience derivation, adrṣṭa, karmaphaladātā.
- Argument: kāryāt must be a reconstruction; the others may be compressed to one or two lines each.
- Distinction: efficient versus material cause; theism versus deism.
- Technical terms: all six Sanskrit route-names, correctly glossed.
- Comparison: one line on the Western parallels (Janet, Lotze, Martineau) and the existence/order divergence.
- Criticism: at least three Indian objectors, briefly.
- Conclusion: cumulative persuasiveness with a modest terminus.

Compact skeleton and timing

1 min : Plurality of proofs; enumerations vary
6 min : Kāryāt in full; āyojanāt, dhṛtyādeḥ, padāt/sruteḥ compressed
3 min : Adrṣṭa argument and karmaphaladātā
2 min : Efficient not material cause; theism not deism
2 min : Evaluation – Mīmāṃsā, Bauddha/Jaina, Carvaka; cumulative verdict
Total : 14 minutes

Common mistakes and examiner penalties

- Answering with the nature of Nyāya's God instead of the proofs: question substitution — a distinct 2021 PYQ.
- Giving only kāryāt: the question says "proofs", plural.
- Omitting the omniscience derivation: loses the argument's most distinctive step.
- Asserting a fixed canonical list of exactly four or exactly ten: enumerations genuinely vary; say so.
- No evaluation at all: "Discuss" requires some.

Part II — 32 Hard UPSC-Style MCQs

Key discipline: Questions 1–32 follow the correct-answer sequence A, B, C, D repeated exactly eight times, with no deviation. Each question has four plausible options, a detailed explanation, and a one-line trap note.

MCQ 1 — The three tiers of assessment

A candidate argues: "Aquinas' Second Way is formally valid, its premises are defensible, and therefore it proves the God of classical theism." Which tier of assessment has the candidate omitted?

- A. Adequacy — whether the being established possesses the unity, infinity, personality and goodness attributed to God by developed religion
- B. Validity — whether the conclusion follows from the premises
- C. Soundness — whether the causal premise is true
- D. Consistency — whether the argument contradicts other arguments in the same system

Answer: A

Explanation: Validity and soundness are the two tiers the candidate has addressed. The missing third tier is adequacy — Kant's charge that the passage from "a necessary being" to "the most real being" is not supplied by cosmological reasoning, and Hume's principle that a cause need only be proportioned to its effect, both live here. D is not a standard tier and would not capture the objection.

 *Trap: a proof may be valid and sound and still fail to establish God.*

MCQ 2 — Classifying the proof-families

Consider the following statements:

1. The ontological argument is the only classical a priori proof of God's existence.
2. Nyāya's Īśvara-anumāna is an a priori argument because it establishes an omniscient being.
3. Kant's moral argument begins from a feature of human experience and is therefore a posteriori in its starting point.
4. Aquinas' Fourth Way begins from the concept of maximal perfection and is therefore a priori.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 1 and 4 only
- B. 1 and 3 only
- C. 2 and 3 only
- D. 1, 2 and 4 only

Answer: B

Explanation: Statement 1 is correct — no other classical proof reasons from the concept alone. Statement 3 is correct: Kant begins from the fact of the moral law and the structure of obligation, an experiential starting point, even though his conclusion is a postulate rather than an inference. Statement 2 is false: Nyāya begins from the world as a composite effect and requires vyāpti established by observation. Statement 4 is false: the Fourth Way begins from observed degrees of goodness and truth, not from a concept.

 *Trap: the modality of the conclusion does not determine whether an argument is a priori; the source of the premises does.*

MCQ 3 — Anselm's two forms

Which statement correctly captures the difference between the arguments of Proslogion 2 and Proslogion 3?

- A. Proslogion 2 establishes necessary existence, while Proslogion 3 establishes existence in the understanding
- B. Both establish exactly the same conclusion, the second being merely a rhetorical restatement
- C. Proslogion 2 argues that existing in reality is greater than existing in the understanding alone, while Proslogion 3 argues that a being which cannot be thought not to exist is greater, thereby establishing necessary existence and aseity
- D. Proslogion 2 is directed at Gaunilo, while Proslogion 3 is directed at Kant

Answer: C

Explanation: The second form upgrades the modal status of the conclusion from bare existence to necessary existence, grounded in God's self-existence; since God as infinitely perfect is not limited by time, both coming-to-be and ceasing-to-be are excluded. A inverts the two forms. B misses the point on which Anselm's whole reply to Gaunilo depends. D is anachronistic in both directions — Gaunilo replies after the Proslogion, and Kant is seven centuries later.

 *Trap: omitting Proslogion 3 makes Anselm's reply to Gaunilo unintelligible.*

MCQ 4 — Gaunilo and Anselm's reply

Assertion (A): Gaunilo's perfect-island parody does not defeat the second form of Anselm's argument. Reason (R): An island is by definition a contingent, dependent part of the physical world and can without contradiction be thought not to exist, whereas God is defined as having eternal and independent existence.

- A. A is true, but R is false
- B. A is false, but R is true
- C. Both A and R are true, but R is not the correct explanation of A
- D. Both A and R are true, and R is the correct explanation of A

Answer: D

Explanation: Anselm's reply is precisely that the element present in the concept of God and absent from the concept of any island is necessary existence; the island, being "a piece of land surrounded by water", is by definition a contingent reality, so Anselm's principle does not apply to it. R therefore explains A exactly. A is not false, and R is not false, ruling out A and B; and the explanatory link is direct, ruling out C.

 *Trap: the reply saves the second form only by transferring the burden to the coherence of maximal greatness.*

MCQ 5 — Kant on existence

Kant's claim that existence is not a "real predicate" is best illustrated by which of the following?

- A. A hundred real thalers contain not one coin more in their concept than a hundred merely possible thalers; existence posits the object rather than enriching the concept
- B. A triangle must have three angles equal to two right angles, so its properties are necessary
- C. A watch found on a heath obliges us to postulate a watchmaker
- D. The stick moves the stone only while the hand moves the stick

Answer: A

Explanation: The thaler illustration is Kant's own, and it isolates precisely the step Anselm and Descartes need — that adding existence to a concept makes it greater. Chatterjee and Datta restate the same point with a hundred rupees imagined in one's pocket. B is Descartes' analogy for the argument, not against it; C is Paley; D is Aquinas' illustration of an essentially ordered series.

 *Trap: Kant's objection is a diagnosis of the concept of existence, not a parody like Gaunilo's.*

MCQ 6 — The modal ontological argument

Which statement most accurately describes the philosophical situation created by modal versions of the ontological argument?

- A. They demonstrate God's existence in system S5 and are therefore immune to all objections
- B. They are formally valid but relocate the entire burden onto the possibility premise, since a symmetrical premise that a maximally great being is possibly non-existent yields the opposite conclusion by the same logic
- C. They abandon necessary existence in favour of contingent existence to escape Kant
- D. They are versions of the cosmological argument, since they begin from the actual world

Answer: B

Explanation: The modal argument's inference is valid given its modal system, but premise 1 — that maximal greatness is possible — is exactly what is in dispute, and its negation is equally available. The dispute therefore shifts from bare existence to the coherence of maximal greatness. A ignores this; C reverses the argument's central device, which is necessary existence; D confuses starting points, since the modal argument's premises are wholly modal-conceptual.

 Trap: "valid" is not "compelling" — validity in S5 is cheap when the possibility premise is contested.

MCQ 7 — Descartes and Anselm

Which pair correctly matches a philosopher with the specific device his version of the ontological argument employs?

- A. Anselm — essence-containment; Descartes — reductio from a comparative
- B. Anselm — inference from the idea of the infinite in a finite mind; Descartes — the perfect-island parody
- C. Anselm — reductio using the comparative "greater"; Descartes — existence as a perfection contained in the essence of a supremely perfect being
- D. Anselm — the possibility premise in S5; Descartes — the second-order analysis of existence

Answer: C

Explanation: Anselm's machinery is a reductio driven by the comparative "greater"; Descartes' is essence-containment, illustrated by the triangle and the mountain-and-valley. A simply swaps them. In B, the first item is Descartes' separate causal proof in Meditations III, and the second is Gaunilo's. D attributes twentieth-century apparatus to both.

 Trap: Descartes' Meditations III causal proof is not his ontological argument.

MCQ 8 — Essentially ordered series

Which of the following is an essentially ordered (per se) causal series of the kind Aquinas argues cannot regress infinitely?

- A. Great-grandfather begets grandfather, who begets father, who begets son
- B. One domino falls and topples the next, which topples the next, over several minutes
- C. A historian's account of successive dynasties, each replacing the last
- D. A hand moves a stick, which moves a stone — where removing the hand stops the entire series at once, because the intermediate members have only derivative causal power

Answer: D

Explanation: In a per se series the members act simultaneously and the intermediates have no independent causal power, so an infinite series of such members would supply no actualising power at all. A and C are accidentally ordered: the earlier members may perish and the effect continues. B is likewise accidentally ordered, since each fallen domino is finished with before the next falls.

Trap: Aquinas does not need to exclude infinite per accidens regresses, and elsewhere allows that the world may be eternal.

MCQ 9 — Mapping the Five Ways

Which of the following correctly maps Aquinas' Ways to their starting points?

- A. Way 1 from change; Way 2 from efficient causation; Way 3 from contingency; Way 4 from degrees of perfection; Way 5 from purposive regularity in things lacking cognition
- B. Way 1 from contingency; Way 2 from degrees; Way 3 from motion; Way 4 from purposiveness; Way 5 from efficient causation
- C. Way 1 from the concept of maximal greatness; Way 2 from motion; Way 3 from moral obligation; Way 4 from scripture; Way 5 from design
- D. Way 1 from the Big Bang; Way 2 from contingency; Way 3 from purposiveness; Way 4 from motion; Way 5 from degrees

Answer: A

Explanation: This is the standard order of Summa Theologiae I, q.2, a.3. B and D scramble the order; C imports the ontological argument, the moral argument and scriptural authority, none of which appear among the Ways — Aquinas presents all five as arguments from reason, *praeambula fidei*.

Trap: Way 4 (degrees) is easily forgotten; omitting it in a Five-Ways question is an immediate content loss.

MCQ 10 — The Third Way's weak step

Consider the following criticisms of Aquinas' Third Way:

1. It may commit a quantifier shift in moving from "for each contingent thing there is a time at which it does not exist" to "there is a time at which nothing exists".
2. It fails because Aquinas assumes the universe began in time, which modern cosmology denies.
3. It requires the further distinction between what is necessary *ab alio* and what is necessary *a se*.
4. It is an *a priori* argument and therefore falls to Kant's objection that existence is not a real predicate.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 1 and 4 only
- B. 1 and 3 only
- C. 2 and 3 only
- D. 2 and 4 only

Answer: B

Explanation: Criticism 1 is the standard logical objection to step 3 of the Way. Criticism 3 is correct: without distinguishing necessity derived from another from necessity of itself, the argument terminates too early. Criticism 2 is false — Aquinas holds that the world's temporal beginning is known by faith, not demonstration, and his argument does not require it. Criticism 4 is false: the Third Way is *a posteriori*, beginning from observed generation and corruption.

Trap: never say Aquinas argues for a temporal beginning; that is the Kalām.

MCQ 11 — Aquinas on the eternity of the world

Which statement is correct about Aquinas' position on whether the universe had a beginning in time?

- A. He demonstrates a temporal beginning from the impossibility of an actual infinite

- B. He denies any beginning and holds the universe to be necessarily eternal
- C. He holds that the universe could, so far as philosophical reason alone can determine, be eternal; that it began is held by faith, and his Ways therefore argue to explanatory rather than temporal priority
- D. He regards the question as meaningless, on the ground that time is a category of the understanding

Answer: C

Explanation: Aquinas himself acknowledges the difficulty of excluding an endless regress of events, and treats creation in time as revealed rather than demonstrated; neo-Thomists accordingly reinterpret the excluded series as one of simultaneous dependence. A describes the Kalām tradition; B misstates Aquinas, who holds the world contingent; D is Kantian, not Thomist.

 *Trap: this single fact separates a first-class Aquinas answer from a textbook one.*

MCQ 12 — Kalām versus Aquinas

Which of the following correctly distinguishes the Kalām cosmological argument from Aquinas' Second Way?

- A. The Kalām is a priori while Aquinas' Second Way is a posteriori
- B. The Kalām concerns degrees of perfection while Aquinas' Second Way concerns motion
- C. The Kalām concludes to an impersonal principle while Aquinas concludes to a personal creator
- D. The Kalām argues that the universe began to exist and therefore has a cause of its beginning, whereas Aquinas' Way argues from present dependence to explanatory priority and does not require a temporal beginning

Answer: D

Explanation: This is the structural difference. Because the Kalām's second premise asserts a temporal beginning, it engages directly with cosmology; Aquinas' argument is deliberately neutral on that question. A is false — both are a posteriori. B misdescribes both. C reverses the usual position, since Kalām defenders typically argue that only agency explains a temporal effect from a timeless cause.

 *Trap: merging Kalām and Aquinas is the commonest structural error in cosmological answers.*

MCQ 13 — Kant against the cosmological argument

Kant's objection that the cosmological argument "rests on the ontological argument" is best understood as the claim that:

- A. The step from "there exists a necessary being" to "that being is the ens realissimum, i.e. God" cannot be made by cosmological reasoning alone and requires the ontological identification of supreme perfection with necessary existence
- B. The cosmological argument's premises are all analytic
- C. Aquinas borrowed his argument from Anselm's Proslogion
- D. The cosmological argument is invalid because infinite regresses are possible

Answer: A

Explanation: Kant's objection operates at the adequacy tier: the cosmological argument delivers "something necessary" and then imports, without acknowledgement, the theologically decisive identification. B is false, since the argument's first premise is empirical. C is a historical claim Kant does not make. D is Hume's objection, not Kant's.

 *Trap: Hume attacks the regress; Kant attacks the identification. Keep the two critics distinct.*

MCQ 14 — Aquinas' Fifth Way and Paley

Which of the following statements is correct?

- A. Aquinas' Fifth Way argues by analogy from human artefacts to the universe, exactly as Paley later does
- B. Aquinas' Fifth Way argues that things lacking cognition act regularly for ends and must therefore be directed by an intelligence — the archer-and-arrow model — whereas Paley's argument is an analogy from artefacts, such as the watch, to organisms
- C. Paley's argument is identical to the modern fine-tuning argument, since both are probabilistic
- D. Neither Aquinas nor Paley offers a teleological argument; both are cosmological

Answer: B

Explanation: The Fifth Way's premise is the regular directedness of non-cognitive nature, which is why Darwinian selection is a less direct competitor to it than to Paley. A collapses the distinction; C confuses an analogical argument with a probabilistic one, and ignores that fine-tuning concerns pre-biological constants; D is simply false.

 *Trap: attributing the watch analogy to Aquinas is explicitly listed among this topic's standard traps.*

MCQ 15 — Paley's supplementary points

Which of the following was not among Paley's supplementary points defending the watch analogy?

- A. The inference is not weakened if we have never actually seen a watch being made
- B. The inference is not invalidated if the mechanism sometimes fails to work perfectly
- C. The inference is strengthened by the fact that the universe contains no evil or waste whatever
- D. The inference is not undermined if some parts have functions we cannot discover

Answer: C

Explanation: Paley's three riders are exactly A, B and D — designed to pre-empt the obvious replies. C is not Paley's claim and is manifestly false; indeed the mixed character of the world is precisely Hume's fifth line of attack, and Paley's second rider is an attempt to blunt it.

 *Trap: Paley concedes imperfection; he does not deny it.*

MCQ 16 — Hume's Epicurean hypothesis

Hume's argument that "any universe capable of persisting must exhibit mutual adaptation of its parts" functions in the Dialogues as:

- A. A concession that design is probable but not certain
- B. A theological argument for a limited deity
- C. An argument that evil disproves a benevolent designer
- D. An undercutting objection showing that apparent adaptation is a precondition of any persisting order rather than evidence of design — reinforced by the Epicurean hypothesis that particles in random motion will, in unlimited time, realise a stable combination

Answer: D

Explanation: This is Hume's first front. It does not concede probability (A), does not argue for a limited deity (B), and is distinct from the argument from evil (C), which is a separate, adequacy-tier front. Hick presents the point with the example that there could not be birds that grew wings but, like fish, could not live in air.

 *Trap: front 1 attacks the evidence; the evil argument attacks the designer's attributes. Different tiers.*

MCQ 17 — Hume on the analogy

Hume's objection that the universe resembles "a great inert animal such as a crustacean, or a vegetable" at least as much as it resembles a machine is intended to show that:

- A. The design inference lacks the strong analogy with a known artefact that alone would license inferring an intelligent designer, since whether vegetables and crustaceans are designed is precisely the point at issue
- B. The universe is alive and therefore divine
- C. Biological organisms cannot be explained mechanistically
- D. Design arguments must be replaced by cosmological arguments

Answer: A

Explanation: The objection is about the strength of the analogy that the argument requires. B and C misread a critical device as a positive cosmology. D proposes a substitution Hume nowhere endorses; his critique of the cosmological argument is separate and equally severe.

 *Trap: Hume's alternative analogies are dialectical devices, not his own metaphysics.*

MCQ 18 — Proportioning cause to effect

Hume's illustration of a pair of scales, where an unseen weight outweighing ten ounces may be inferred to exceed ten ounces but never to be infinite, supports which conclusion?

- A. That the design argument is formally invalid
- B. That even if a designer may be inferred, from a finite world one can never infer an infinite, perfectly good and unique creator — an objection to the adequacy of the conclusion rather than to the evidence
- C. That the universe must have had many designers working in succession
- D. That natural selection explains adaptation without design

Answer: B

Explanation: The scales illustration formalises the principle that a cause need only be proportioned to the effect from which it is inferred. A misidentifies the tier of the objection; C is Hume's fourth front, a distinct argument; D is Darwin's contribution, not Hume's.

 *Trap: this objection grants the inference and then denies its reach — the classic adequacy move.*

MCQ 19 — The exact scope of Darwin's defeat

Which statement most accurately describes what Darwinian natural selection removes from the design debate?

- A. It removes the possibility of any teleological reasoning whatever
- B. It removes the fine-tuning of cosmological constants as evidence for design
- C. It removes biological adaptation — Paley's central evidence — as a datum requiring intelligent design, while leaving untouched the law-governedness of nature and the pre-biological fine-tuning of physical constants
- D. It removes Aquinas' Fifth Way, since that argument depends on the adaptation of organisms

Answer: C

Explanation: Hick's ozone illustration makes the point vividly: life fitted itself to the radiation that penetrates the ozone layer, rather than the layer being installed to protect pre-existing life. A overstates; B is precisely wrong, since fine-tuning is pre-biological and untouched by biological selection; D misstates the Fifth Way, whose premise is the regular directedness of non-cognitive nature, not organic adaptation.

 *Trap: Darwin defeats Paley, not teleology as such.*

MCQ 20 — Fine-tuning and its rivals

Which of the following best characterises the contemporary fine-tuning argument and the principal objection to it?

- A. It is an analogical argument from artefacts, refuted by Darwin
- B. It is an a priori argument from the concept of a designer, refuted by Kant
- C. It is a deductive proof from the constants of physics, refuted by the fallacy of composition
- D. It is a probabilistic inference to the best explanation from the narrow life-permitting range of physical constants, and its principal rivals are multiverse hypotheses combined with observation-selection effects, or brute physical necessity

Answer: D

Explanation: Fine-tuning arguments are Bayesian or explanatory rather than analogical or deductive, and their live competitors are cosmological rather than biological. A confuses fine-tuning with Paley; B misclassifies it as a priori; C misdescribes both its logical form and the relevant objection.

 *Trap: mention fine-tuning as a modern extension; never let it displace Paley and Hume in a UPSC answer.*

MCQ 21 — Kant's postulates

Which set correctly lists Kant's postulates of practical reason?

- A. Freedom, immortality and God
- B. God, the moral law and the categorical imperative
- C. Freedom, the highest good and the ens realissimum
- D. Immortality, providence and grace

Answer: A

Explanation: Freedom is presupposed by obligation itself; immortality is postulated because holiness is unattainable in finite time; God is postulated because nature does not proportion happiness to virtue. In B, the moral law is a fact of reason, not a postulate, and the categorical imperative is its formulation. C mixes an object of the will with a term from theoretical theology. D imports Christian theological categories Kant does not postulate.

 *Trap: listing only God loses the systematic architecture of the argument.*

MCQ 22 — The role of "ought implies can"

In Kant's moral argument, the principle that "ought implies can" functions to establish that:

- A. Every moral agent is capable of achieving the highest good unaided
- B. Since reason commands us to promote the highest good, the highest good must be really possible — which in turn requires conditions (endless moral progress, and a cause of nature able to proportion happiness to virtue) that only the postulates supply
- C. Moral obligation is conditional upon belief in God
- D. God's existence follows deductively from the existence of moral obligation

Answer: B

Explanation: The principle secures the real possibility of the commanded object, and the postulates are the conditions of that possibility. A is exactly what Kant denies, which is why the postulates are needed. C reverses Kant's doctrine of autonomy — obligation is unconditional and independent of theology. D describes the inferential first form, not Kant's postulational one.

 *Trap: the highest good must be promotable, not single-handedly achievable.*

MCQ 23 — Newman's conscience argument

Hick's central objection to the inferential form of the moral argument, exemplified by Newman's Grammar of Assent, is that it:

- A. Contradicts the doctrine of divine simplicity
- B. Confuses the moral law with the categorical imperative
- C. Assumes that moral values admit of no naturalistic explanation in terms of human needs, desires, social structures or the constitution of human nature — and thereby begs the question against the very sceptic it addresses
- D. Relies on an unestablished possibility premise

Answer: C

Explanation: The inference from conscience to a divine addressee requires that conscience not be naturalistically explicable, which is precisely what is in dispute; from the naturalistic sceptic's standpoint nothing has been established. A is irrelevant; B confuses two Kantian items; D belongs to the modal ontological argument.

 *Trap: Kant's second form escapes this objection because it postulates rather than infers.*

MCQ 24 — The target of the Euthyphro dilemma

The Euthyphro dilemma — is the good good because God wills it, or does God will it because it is good? — is a serious objection to:

- A. Kant's postulate of God as the condition of the highest good's possibility
- B. Anselm's second form of the ontological argument
- C. Nyāya's inference from the composite character of the world
- D. Divine-command theories that make God's will the source and standard of moral goodness

Answer: D

Explanation: The dilemma forces divine-command theorists to choose between arbitrariness (anything God willed would be good) and a standard independent of God (which demotes God from the source of morality). Kant is insulated, since for him the moral law is autonomous and God guarantees only the proportioning of happiness to virtue; B and C are not moral arguments at all.

 *Trap: aiming Euthyphro at Kant is a misapplied objection and is penalised.*

MCQ 25 — Nyāya's divine causation

Which statement correctly describes God's causal role in Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika?

- A. God is the intelligent efficient cause who orders eternally existing atoms, preserves the world by His will and destroys it when the moral order requires — atoms remaining the material cause
- B. God transforms His own essence into atoms, souls and space
- C. God creates the world at a moment and thereafter has no concern with it, intervening only in emergencies
- D. God is both the efficient and the material cause, the world and selves forming His body

Answer: A

Explanation: Nyāya's God is a demiurgus or builder, not a material source. B is a Vedāntic transformation model; C is deism, which Chatterjee and Datta explicitly distinguish from Nyāya theism on the ground that God maintains a continuous relation with the world; D is Rāmānuja's Viśiṣṭādvaita.

 *Trap: calling Nyāya's God the material cause is the topic's most heavily penalised factual error.*

MCQ 26 — The kāryāt argument's internal steps

Consider the following statements about the Nyāya causal argument:

1. Composite objects are known to be effects because they are made of parts and possess intermediate magnitude.
2. Space, time, ether and self are treated as effects because they are perceptible.
3. The intelligent cause must be omniscient, because only an omniscient being can have direct knowledge of atoms.
4. Atoms of earth, water, light and air are excluded from the class of effects because they are simple, indivisible and infinitesimal.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 1, 2 and 3 only
- B. 1, 3 and 4 only
- C. 2 and 4 only
- D. 1 and 2 only

Answer: B

Explanation: Statements 1, 3 and 4 reproduce the argument exactly: sāvayava and avāntara-mahattva are the marks of effect-hood; atoms and manas are excluded as simple infinitesimals; and the derivation of omniscience turns on the requirement of directly knowing atoms. Statement 2 is false — space, time, ether and self are excluded from effect-hood precisely because they are infinite substances not made up of parts, and they are not perceptible in the required way.

 *Trap: the omniscience step is what lifts the argument from "an intelligent artisan" to "God"; omitting it guts the proof.*

MCQ 27 — The argument from adṛṣṭa

The Nyāya argument from adṛṣṭa concludes to God because:

- A. Adṛṣṭa is a divine attribute and therefore presupposes God
- B. Without God the law of karma would produce no effects at all
- C. Adṛṣṭa, being an unintelligent principle, cannot by itself allot precisely the kind and degree of joy and sorrow deserved, while individual selves neither know their own adṛṣṭa nor control it — so an omniscient dispenser is required
- D. The Vedas declare that adṛṣṭa is created afresh by God at the start of each world-cycle

Answer: C

Explanation: Adṛṣṭa is the stock of merit (puṇya) and demerit (pāpa) generated by the soul's own past actions, introduced to bridge the time-gap between act and consequence. The argument turns on its unconsciousness. A inverts the doctrine; B overstates the claim, which concerns determinate allocation rather than efficacy as such; D contradicts adṛṣṭa's origin in the agent's own karma.

 *Trap: the Mīmāṃsā counter — that apūrva matures by itself — is aimed exactly at this premise.*

MCQ 28 — The Veda–God circularity

Nyāya's reply to the charge that it proves God from the Veda and the Veda from God is that:

- A. The charge is conceded, and the two arguments are therefore abandoned
- B. Scripture is not really used, since both arguments are purely inferential
- C. Circularity is acceptable in theology though not in logic
- D. The dependence runs in different orders: in the order of existence God creates the Veda and imparts its authority, while in the order of knowledge the Veda leads us to God — and reciprocal dependence across two different orders is

not a vicious circle

Answer: D

Explanation: The reply adds that the Veda does not depend on God for our knowledge of it, since it may be learned from a competent teacher, while God does not depend on the Veda for His existence. Circularity would arise only within one and the same order or universe of discourse. A concedes what the tradition answers; B is false, since two of the standard proofs are explicitly scriptural; C is not a reply Nyāya offers.

 *Trap: conceding the circle throws away one of the most elegant replies in Indian philosophy of religion.*

MCQ 29 — Jaina godhead

Which statement most accurately expresses the Jaina position on God?

- A. Jainism denies God as creator of the world but affirms godhead: every liberated soul is a god, and the Tīrthaṅkaras were mortals who attained that state by personal effort
- B. Jainism affirms a single eternal creator who arranges the six substances
- C. Jainism accepts the Vedic testimony to God while rejecting inference as a pramāṇa
- D. Jainism identifies God with the totality of material substance

Answer: A

Explanation: The world was never created; substances are eternal and change through modes, so no creator is required. Godhood is achieved, plural, non-creative and exemplary — "we are all potential Jinas". B contradicts the doctrine that the world is uncreated; C contradicts Jainism's rejection of Vedic authority; D describes a materialist pantheism alien to Jaina pluralism.

 *Trap: answering the 2019 PYQ with "Jainism is atheistic" misreads the question and forfeits most of the marks.*

MCQ 30 — The Buddhist immutability argument

The Buddhist argument that a permanent, immutable God cannot be the creator of the world proceeds by claiming that:

- A. An immutable being cannot be omniscient, since knowledge of a changing world would change it
- B. A cause that is eternal, unchanging and fully present at all times should produce its effect always and all at once, and therefore cannot account for a world of temporally successive events
- C. An immutable being cannot be good, since goodness requires responsiveness to suffering
- D. An immutable being could not have created atoms, since atoms are eternal

Answer: B

Explanation: This is the Dharmakīrti-type line, and it targets the compatibility of immutability with successive production. A and C are distinct objections about omniscience and goodness respectively, which the tradition raises separately. D is a Nyāya-internal thesis about material causation, not a Buddhist argument against a creator.

 *Trap: classical theism replies with a single eternal act producing a temporal effect; a "critically evaluate" answer must include that reply.*

MCQ 31 — Mīmāṃsā's twin displacement of God

Which pair of Mīmāṃsā doctrines together dispenses with the two Nyāya arguments that appeal, respectively, to Vedic authority and to the dispensing of karmic fruit?

- A. Anekāntavāda and syādvāda
- B. Pratītyasamutpāda and anātman

C. Apauruṣeya — the Veda is eternal and authorless, so no divine author is needed — and apūrva, the unseen potency of correctly performed ritual that matures into future fruit without a divine dispenser

D. Vivarta and māyā

Answer: C

Explanation: These two doctrines strike Nyāya's third proof and its adṛṣṭa proof simultaneously. Mīmāṃsā adds that Nyāya's route is cumbersome, requiring one first to prove God exists, then that God is omniscient, then that God intends truth. A is Jaina, B Buddhist, D Advaitic.

 Trap: apūrva is Mīmāṃsā's technical substitute for a fruit-dispensing God; do not call it "karma" loosely.

MCQ 32 — Comparative synthesis

Which of the following is the most defensible comparative judgement about Western and Indian proofs for God?

- A. Nyāya's kāryāt argument and Aquinas' Second Way are identical, since both terminate in a first cause of the world's existence
- B. Indian philosophy possesses an ontological argument in Advaita's derivation of Brahman from the concept of pure being
- C. Hume's analogy objection has no application to Nyāya, whose inference is not analogical
- D. Both traditions build a posteriori inferences from order to intelligence and face objections on the same tiers; but they diverge decisively over material causation — Aquinas' God confers being, whereas Nyāya's Īśvara only orders eternally existing atoms — and India's sharpest anti-theistic critiques come from within orthodoxy

Answer: D

Explanation: A ignores the material-causation divergence, which is the single most important comparative point. B manufactures an Indian ontological argument; Brahman is disclosed through śruti and anubhava, not established by conceptual analysis. C is false — Nyāya's inference is expressly modelled on pot and potter (ghaṭavat) and is therefore squarely exposed to Hume's objection.

 Trap: the phrase "India's critics stood inside religion, the West's outside it" is the highest-value comparative line in this topic.

Part III — Remedial MCQs and Notes on Recurring Category Errors

These target the six category errors that cost the most marks in this syllabus item. Attempt them only after Part II.

Remedial R1 — "Proof", "postulate" and "inference"

A student writes: "Kant proved the existence of God from the moral law." Which correction is required?

- A. Kant inferred God from the objectivity of moral values, as Newman did
- B. Kant postulated God as a condition of the real possibility of the highest good; a postulate of practical reason is theoretically undemonstrable and is an object of rational faith, not knowledge
- C. Kant demonstrated God's existence but only for practical purposes, which counts as a proof
- D. Kant proved immortality but not God

Answer: B · Note: the Critique of Pure Reason denies speculative theology; the Critique of Practical Reason supplies postulates, not proofs. Writing "Kant proves God" is the topic's single most penalised sentence.

Remedial R2 — Efficient versus material causation

A student writes: "In Nyāya, God creates the atoms and then arranges them." Which correction is required?

- A. God creates neither atoms nor souls; atoms are eternal and are the material cause, while God is the intelligent efficient cause who orders them, and also preserves and destroys the world
- B. God creates the atoms but not the souls
- C. God is the material cause and the atoms are His modes
- D. God neither creates nor orders; the atoms combine automatically

Answer: A · Note: D is the Cārvāka position; C is Vedāntic. The efficient/material distinction (nimitta- versus upādāna-kāraṇa) must appear in the opening lines of any Nyāya answer.

Remedial R3 — Which critic said what

Match the objection to its author: (i) the perfect-island parody; (ii) "existence is not a real predicate"; (iii) the scales illustration; (iv) the archer and the arrow.

- A. (i) Kant, (ii) Gaunilo, (iii) Paley, (iv) Hume
- B. (i) Hume, (ii) Gaunilo, (iii) Kant, (iv) Paley
- C. (i) Gaunilo, (ii) Kant, (iii) Hume, (iv) Aquinas
- D. (i) Gaunilo, (ii) Hume, (iii) Kant, (iv) Paley

Answer: C · Note: the archer–arrow belongs to Aquinas' Fifth Way, not to Paley, whose image is the watch. Misattribution here is the fastest way to lose examiner confidence.

Remedial R4 — Aquinas versus Kalām

A student writes: "Aquinas' Second Way proves that the universe began to exist and that God caused the beginning." Which correction is required?

- A. Aquinas proves an infinite regress is possible
- B. Aquinas' argument concerns present, simultaneous dependence and explanatory priority; he holds that the temporal beginning of the world is known by faith rather than demonstrated, and it is the Kalām argument that asserts a beginning
- C. Aquinas proves a beginning, but by the Third Way rather than the Second
- D. Aquinas's argument is a priori and therefore says nothing about time

Answer: B · Note: if you write only one sentence about Aquinas, make it this one.

Remedial R5 — What Hume actually establishes

A student writes: "Hume proved that the universe has no designer." Which correction is required?

- A. Hume proved there are many designers rather than one
- B. Hume proved that natural selection explains adaptation
- C. Hume's target is the strength of the inference and the attributes of the being inferred; in the Dialogues, Philo himself concedes a remote and undefined analogy between the cause of order and human intelligence
- D. Hume abandoned the design argument in favour of the cosmological argument

Answer: C · Note: B is Darwin, seventy years later. A is one of Hume's dialectical alternatives, not his conclusion.

Remedial R6 — Jainism, Buddhism and Mīmāṃsā are not one position

Which statement correctly differentiates the three Indian anti-creator positions?

- A. All three deny God because none accepts inference as a pramāṇa
- B. All three deny God because they deny the reality of the external world

C. All three deny God because they accept the eternity of the Veda

D. Jainism denies a creator because the world is uncreated and karma is material and self-operating, while affirming godhood in the liberated soul; Buddhism denies a creator because dependent origination explains arising through conditions and an immutable cause cannot yield succession; Mīmāṃsā denies a creator because the Veda is *apauruṣeya* and *apūrva* matures without a dispenser

Answer: D · Note: A confuses them with Cārvāka; B is false of all three; C is true only of Mīmāṃsā and is flatly denied by the other two, which reject Vedic authority altogether.

Remedial R7 — Validity, soundness, adequacy

Which objection operates at the soundness tier rather than the adequacy tier?

A. From a finite world one may infer only a finite cause

B. The universe resembles a vegetable as much as a machine, so the analogy required by the argument is too weak to support the inference

C. The cause established need not be one rather than many

D. A first cause need not be morally good

Answer: B · Note: A, C and D all grant an inference and question the attributes of its terminus. Sorting objections by tier is the fastest route to an evaluative conclusion.

Remedial R8 — Register of the concluding verdict

Which concluding sentence would earn the most credit in a 20-mark answer?

A. "Thus God's existence is proved beyond doubt by the cumulative weight of the arguments."

B. "Thus no argument works and religion is irrational."

C. "Thus the arguments are interesting but inconclusive, and the matter remains a personal belief."

D. "Judged by evidential contact the a posteriori proofs are stronger, judged by modal strength the a priori is; but neither closes the gap between the being established and the God of developed religion, which is why every tradition — Thomist, Kantian and Nyāya alike — eventually supplements proof with experience or testimony."

Answer: D · Note: D names its criteria, grades its verdict and is comparative. C is the "safe" conclusion most candidates write; it earns few evaluative marks because it names no criterion.

Part IV — Ten Original Solved Mains Questions

Distribution: three 10-markers, four 15-markers, three 20-markers. Each carries demand decoding, a model answer written to the appropriate length, and a top-answer checklist.

Original 10-marker 1

Question: Distinguish an essentially ordered from an accidentally ordered causal series, and explain why the distinction is indispensable to Aquinas' Second Way. (10 marks, 150 words)

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	Distinguish and explain why — a conceptual distinction put to argumentative work
Core issue	Why Aquinas may exclude one infinite regress without excluding all

Element	Requirement
Ideal thesis	The distinction shows that "first" means explanatory, not temporal, priority

Model answer (≈155 words)

An accidentally ordered (per accidens) series is one in which each cause, having produced its effect, may perish while the effect continues — as a grandfather begets a father who begets a son. Its members possess causal power in their own right, and an infinite backward series of such causes is not obviously incoherent; Aquinas indeed holds that reason alone cannot exclude an eternal world.

An essentially ordered (per se) series is one in which the members act simultaneously and the intermediates possess only derivative power: the hand moves the stick, which moves the stone. Remove the hand and the whole series stops at once.

The distinction is indispensable because Aquinas' exclusion of infinite regress applies only to the second kind. An unlimited series of borrowers with no owner explains nothing, since no member supplies non-derivative actualising power. Hence "first cause" denotes explanatory priority here and now, not the earliest event in time — which is why the Second Way is not an argument for a temporal beginning.

Top-answer checklist

- Both series named in Latin and illustrated.
- Simultaneity and derivative power identified as the marks of the per se series.
- The hand–stick–stone example present.
- "First" explicitly glossed as explanatory.
- One line noting that Aquinas permits an eternal world philosophically.

Original 10-marker 2

Question: "Jainism denies God but not godhead." Examine. (10 marks, 150 words)

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	Examine — test the accuracy and implications of the formula
Core issue	Two senses of "God": world-maker and perfected being
Ideal thesis	The formula is accurate: Jainism rejects jagat-kartā and affirms attainable divinity

Model answer (≈160 words)

The formula is accurate and philosophically precise. Jainism denies God as creator: the world was never made, since all six substances are eternal and reality is characterised by origination, decay and permanence (utpāda–vyaya–dhrauvya); change belongs to modes, not to a divine act. It reinforces this with anti-creator arguments — a perfect being can have no motive to create; creation from compassion is refuted by suffering; creation as sport is childish and cruel; and if God is self-existent, the world may equally be so.

Yet godhead is affirmed. Every jīva intrinsically possesses infinite knowledge, perception, bliss and power, obscured by material karma; complete removal of that obscuration yields kevala-jñāna, and the liberated soul is a siddha — a god. The Tīrthaṅkaras were mortals who reached this by personal effort: "we are all potential Jinās."

Jaina divinity is therefore plural, achieved, non-creative and exemplary. It answers the soteriological question, not the cosmological one — which is why the label "atheism" misdescribes it.

Top-answer checklist

- The two senses of "God" separated in the opening line.
- Utpāda-vyaya-dhrauvya cited for the uncreated world.
- At least two anti-creator arguments.
- Ananta-catuṣṭaya, kevala-jñāna, siddha used accurately.
- The closing characterisation: plural, achieved, non-creative, exemplary.

Original 10-marker 3

Question: Explain why Nyāya holds that adrṣṭa cannot operate without God, and state the strongest objection to this claim. (10 marks, 150 words)

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	Explain and state — reconstruction plus one targeted objection
Core issue	Whether an unconscious moral residue can allot determinate consequences
Ideal thesis	Nyāya's claim rests on unconsciousness; Mīmāṃsā's apūrva is its strongest rival

Model answer (~155 words)

Differences in human fortune are events and must have causes; those causes are our own past actions, in this or a previous life. But consequences are often separated from acts by long intervals — "a sinner in the heyday of youth may be a sufferer in the infirmity of old age." Nyāya therefore posits a persisting stock of merit (puṇya) and demerit (pāpa), called adrṣṭa.

The decisive step follows: adrṣṭa is an unintelligent principle, and cannot by itself produce precisely the kind and degree of joy and sorrow deserved. Individual selves cannot direct it either, since they neither know their own adrṣṭa nor can control it. Hence an eternal, omniscient and omnipotent dispenser is required — God as karmaphaladātā.

The strongest objection is Mīmāṃsā's: apūrva, the unseen potency generated by correctly performed ritual, persists and matures into its own fruit without any dispenser. If an unconscious potency can be intrinsically fruit-directed, Nyāya's premise fails — and with it the argument.

Top-answer checklist

- The time-gap problem stated as the reason for positing adrṣṭa.
- Puṇya and pāpa named.
- Unconsciousness identified as the load-bearing premise.
- Karmaphaladātā used.
- The Mīmāṃsā apūrva counter given as the objection, not a generic "karma suffices".

Original 15-marker 1

Question: Does the modal version of the ontological argument escape Kant's objection? Discuss. (15 marks, 240 words)

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	Discuss an evaluative question demanding a verdict
Core issue	Whether necessary existence is a modal status immune to the real-predicate objection
Ideal thesis	It escapes the letter of Kant's objection but not its spirit, because the burden migrates to the possibility premise

Model answer (~250 words)

Kant's objection is that existence is not a real or determining predicate: it adds nothing to a concept but posits its object, as a hundred real thalers add no concept to a hundred possible ones. If so, Anselm's comparative — that existing in reality is greater — is illegitimate, and the argument builds its conclusion into its premise.

Modal reconstructions by Malcolm, Hartshorne and, most influentially, Plantinga work exclusively with Anselm's second form. Their claim is that the relevant property is not bare existence but necessary existence, a modal status. The argument runs: it is possible that a maximally great being exists; a maximally great being exists necessarily and is maximally excellent in every possible world; what is possibly necessary is, in S5, actually necessary; therefore such a being exists.

This does escape Kant's objection as stated: modal status is arguably a genuine property of a being, and the inference does not require existence to enhance a concept.

But it does not escape the objection's spirit. The entire weight now falls on the possibility premise. A symmetrical premise — that it is possible that no maximally great being exists — yields, in the same modal system, the contradictory conclusion. The premises are thus evidentially on a par, and the argument establishes nothing until it is independently shown that maximal greatness is coherent. That is precisely the question Kant's objection was raising in another form: whether the concept of God can be so specified that its analysis yields existence.

Verdict: the modal version converts an objection about the logic of existence into a dispute about the coherence of maximal greatness. This is philosophical progress, not vindication.

Top-answer checklist

- Kant's objection stated with the thaler illustration.
- The modal argument given as numbered steps, with S5 named.
- The escape acknowledged honestly before the counter is made.
- The symmetry of the possibility premise displayed.
- A graded verdict — progress, not vindication.

Original 15-marker 2

Question: Examine the Mīmāṃsā case that the authority of the Veda and the operation of karma together render a creator God redundant. (15 marks, 240 words)

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	Examine — reconstruct the case and test it
Core issue	Whether normativity and desert can be secured without a divine guarantor
Ideal thesis	The case is coherent and internally powerful, but purchases economy at the cost of explaining normativity's ultimate ground

Model answer (~250 words)

Mīmāṃsā's case has two limbs, each aimed at a distinct Nyāya proof.

The first concerns authority. The Veda is *apauruṣeya* — eternal, authorless and self-valid. Authorlessness is not a deficiency but a protection: a personal author may deceive or may lack complete knowledge, and if the Veda had an author, its authority would depend on first proving that author's competence and sincerity. Mīmāṃsā presses the point directly against Nyāya: the theistic route requires proving that God exists, then that God is omniscient, then that God intends truth, each stage needing independent support. Combined with *svataḥ-prāmāṇya*, the intrinsic validity of cognition, authorlessness blocks scepticism at the outset without theological machinery.

The second concerns desert. *Apūrva* is the unseen potency generated by correctly performed ritual; it persists after the act and matures into future fruit. *Prābhākara* adds *niyoga*: the injunction itself creates obligation, so one acts because the Veda commands, not because a deity rewards. Together these dissolve Nyāya's *adṛṣṭa* argument, whose whole force lay in the claim that an unconscious principle cannot allot determinate fruit.

Two criticisms remain. First, an eternal, authorless language that nevertheless carries determinate normative content is itself philosophically striking, and Nyāya charges that unexplained normativity is not the same as economical explanation. Second, Chatterjee and Datta observe that Mīmāṃsā's deities are not treated as objects of worship and are said to exist nowhere except in the mantras describing them, so God is left in an "ambiguous position" — economy achieved partly by evacuation.

Verdict: the case succeeds in showing that a rigorous account of duty and desert is possible without a creator; it does not show that such an account is explanatorily superior.

Top-answer checklist

- The two limbs separated and matched to the two Nyāya proofs they attack.
- *Apauruṣeya*, *svataḥ-prāmāṇya*, *apūrva* and *niyoga* all used correctly.
- The "cumbersome three-stage dependence" objection to Nyāya reproduced.
- At least one criticism from the Nyāya side and one from the textbook tradition.
- A graded verdict distinguishing possibility from superiority.

Original 15-marker 3

Question: "The failure of the theistic proofs establishes atheism." Critically examine. (15 marks, 240 words)

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	Critically examine a stated thesis; you must adjudicate it
Core issue	The logical relation between failed arguments and the falsity of their conclusion
Ideal thesis	The claim commits the fallacy of arguing from failed argument to false conclusion

Model answer (≈250 words)

The thesis is false, and its falsity is instructive.

Formally, the inference from "the arguments for *p* have failed" to "*p* is false" is invalid. Failure of an argument shows only that that route does not establish its conclusion; the conclusion may still be true, and may be supported otherwise. Every proof examined here fails at a definable point — Anselm at the comparative premise, Aquinas at the exclusion of regress or the identification with God, Paley at the analogy, Kant at the transition from postulate to knowledge, Nyāya at the artefact model and the sufficiency of karma. None of these failures is a demonstration that no God exists.

The tradition itself supports this. Chatterjee and Datta, having concluded with Kant and Lotze that God cannot be deduced from anterior premises — since God, being ultimate, is "the highest of all premises" — draw an experiential, not atheistic, conclusion: God must be known through direct experience. Lotze's formulation is that all proofs are "pleas

put forward in justification of our faith". Hume's Philo likewise concedes a remote analogy between the cause of order and intelligence even while dismantling the design inference.

Two qualifications are owed to the thesis. First, if all available routes fail, that may lower the rational credibility of theism, and an evidentialist can reasonably say so. Second, arguments against theism — most seriously the evidential problem of evil — are independent, and their force is untouched by the present point.

Verdict: the failure of the proofs establishes the failure of natural theology as demonstration, not atheism. It relocates the question from proof to experience, testimony, cumulative probability and the problem of evil.

Top-answer checklist

- The invalid inference named and explained.
- Each family's specific point of failure identified, not merely asserted.
- The Chatterjee–Datta/Lotze experiential conclusion cited.
- Philo's concession noted.
- Two honest qualifications granted before the verdict.

Original 15-marker 4

Question: Compare Kant's postulation of God from the highest good with Nyāya's inference of God as karmaphaladātā. (15 marks, 250 words)

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	Compare — sustained axis-by-axis, not two summaries
Core issue	Two responses to the same problem — the disproportion of virtue and happiness
Ideal thesis	Same problem, different epistemic ambition: Kant claims rational hope, Nyāya claims knowledge

Model answer (~255 words)

Both address one problem: nature does not proportion happiness to desert. Their responses diverge in epistemic ambition, and that divergence determines their respective vulnerabilities.

Kant. Having demolished the speculative proofs, he argues that the moral law commands us to promote the highest good, virtue together with proportionate happiness; "ought implies can" requires that this be really possible; but a finite agent cannot secure the harmony of virtue and happiness, nor achieve holiness in finite time. Hence the postulates of freedom, immortality and God. A postulate is practically necessary and theoretically undemonstrable — rational faith, not knowledge.

Nyāya. Differences of fortune require causes; karma supplies them; the time-gap requires a persisting stock of merit and demerit, *adr̥ṣṭa*; and *adr̥ṣṭa*, being unconscious, cannot allot determinate results, while selves neither know nor control it. Hence God as karmaphaladātā, "the impartial dispenser of the fruits of our actions". Strikingly, Chatterjee and Datta gloss this in Kant's own idiom: "it is God who combines happiness with virtue and misery with vice."

The convergence is therefore substantive, not verbal: both make God the guarantor of moral proportion, and both treat that proportioning as beyond the powers of finite agents.

The divergence is decisive. Kant postulates a God who could proportion; Nyāya infers a God who does. Kant's conclusion is modest and correspondingly hard to refute — one may decline the postulate, but not refute it. Nyāya's is bolder and correspondingly exposed: it must defeat the Mīmāṃsā claim that *apūrva* is self-fructifying, and it must survive the charge, pressed by C. D. Sharma, that a God chained by *adr̥ṣṭa* is a supervisor the system could do without.

Verdict: Kant secures less and risks less; Nyāya claims more and stakes more. Neither reaches the God of developed religion.

Top-answer checklist

- The shared problem stated in the opening line.
- Kant's derivation given as steps, with all three postulates.
- Adṛṣṭa, karmaphaladātā and the unconsciousness premise present.
- The Chatterjee–Datta gloss quoted as evidence of a genuine parallel.
- The epistemic-ambition contrast made the axis of the verdict.

Original 20-marker 1

Question: "Hume did not disprove design; he dismantled the inference." Critically examine with reference to the Dialogues Concerning Natural Religion. (20 marks, 340 words)

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	Critically examine a precise interpretive thesis
Core issue	The logical status of Hume's conclusions
Ideal thesis	The thesis is correct: Hume's attacks are undercutting and adequacy-directed, not disproofs

Model answer (~350 words)

The thesis is correct, and defending it requires separating two waves of Hume's attack.

The design argument, in Paley's form, is an analogy: a watch on a heath, with wheels, cogs and springs adjusted to a purpose, obliges us to postulate a maker; organisms exhibit comparable means–end adjustment; therefore they too imply a designer. Paley's three riders pre-empt the obvious replies — the inference survives never having seen a watch made, imperfect working, and parts of unknown function — and he builds a long cumulative case from the eye, the wing, the fin, planetary motion and the seasons.

Hume's first wave is undercutting. He argues that any universe capable of persisting must display mutual adaptation, so adaptation is a precondition of order rather than evidence of design; the Epicurean hypothesis — a finite number of particles in random motion passing, in unlimited time, through every combination, one of which is stable — supplies a naturalistic model of order. He then attacks the analogy itself: the universe is as like a vegetable or a crustacean as a machine, and whether those are designed is the point at issue.

His second wave is adequacy-directed. Cause must be proportioned to effect, so from a finite world one may infer only a finite cause — the illustration of the scales, where an unseen weight may be inferred to exceed ten ounces but never to be infinite. The evidence equally supports many designers, an inferior deity, an infant or senile one, or a bungled first attempt; and the world's evil and disorder tell against a good and powerful designer.

Neither wave is a disproof. Undercutting objections show the evidence does not support the conclusion; they do not show the conclusion false. Adequacy objections grant an inference and deny only its reach. Hume's own Philo concedes a remote, undefined analogy between the cause of order in the universe and human intelligence. Darwin later supplies the mechanism Hume lacked, removing Paley's biological premise — Hick's ozone example inverts the intuition — but that too is an explanation, not a refutation. Modern fine-tuning arguments answer Hume's first wave by relocating the evidence to pre-biological constants, while remaining fully exposed to the second and facing multiverse rivals.

Verdict: the thesis stands. Hume destroyed the argument's demonstrative pretension and blocked the passage from an orderer to the one, infinite, perfectly good God of theism. What survives is design as an inference to the best explanation — contested, cumulative, and never compelling.

Top-answer checklist

- The two waves explicitly distinguished and labelled by tier.

- Paley's three riders present.
- At least four Hume fronts with his own illustrations.
- Philo's concession cited as the decisive textual evidence for the thesis.
- Darwin and fine-tuning placed with their exact scope.
- A verdict naming what survives, not merely what fails.

Original 20-marker 2

Question: "Every Indian argument against a creator God is either an economy move, a coherence move or an epistemic move." Critically examine this classification with reference to Jaina, Buddhist, Mīmāṃsā and Cārvāka positions. (20 marks, 340 words)

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	Critically examine a proposed taxonomy — test its fit and its limits
Core issue	Whether four distinct schools share a common argumentative structure
Ideal thesis	The classification fits well and is analytically useful, but some arguments straddle categories and one school resists placement

Model answer (~350 words)

The classification is largely accurate and analytically valuable, though it requires two qualifications.

Economy moves claim that the explanandum is already explained. Buddhism's *pratītyasamutpāda* accounts for the arising of phenomena through conditions, making a creator superfluous; the critique is a systematic refusal of explanatory surplus rather than bare denial. Jainism holds that the world was never created — substances are eternal and change through modes — and that material karma, adhering to each *jīva*, accounts for the distribution of fortune. Mīmāṃsā's *apūrva* matures into its own fruit, displacing the need for a dispenser. Cārvāka holds that the world is made by the automatic combination of the material elements.

Coherence moves claim that the divine attributes are inconsistent with the act of creating. Buddhism argues that an eternal, immutable cause cannot produce successive effects, and that creation from desire implies lack. Jainism asks what God created from, why a perfect being would create at all, and why a compassionate creator's world contains suffering. Chatterjee and Datta record Max Müller's related point that a creator would be liable to charges of cruelty and partiality.

Epistemic moves deny that the required *pramāṇa* is available. Cārvāka restricts valid cognition to perception, which undercuts every inferential proof at the outset. Mīmāṃsā's *svataḥ-prāmāṇya* and *apauruṣeya* make Vedic authority intrinsic, so no divine certifier is needed; Nyāya's route, requiring one to prove God, then omniscience, then truthfulness, is dismissed as cumbersome.

Two qualifications. First, several arguments straddle categories: the Jaina "if God is self-existent, so may the world be" is simultaneously a parity argument and an economy argument, and Buddhism's *avyākṛta* silence is methodological rather than any of the three. Second, Jainism does not fit a purely negative taxonomy, since it also affirms godhood — every liberated soul is a god — so its position is not exhausted by objections to a creator.

Nyāya's replies fall into matching families: against economy, that an unconscious principle cannot allot determinate desert; against coherence, that divine agency need not be modelled on finite volition; against epistemic restriction, that inference is an independent *pramāṇa* which the Cārvāka's own general denial presupposes.

Verdict: the taxonomy is a genuine advance over school-by-school listing, because it exposes that Indian and Western critiques share the same three structures — Hume's Epicurean hypothesis is an economy move, his proportioning principle a coherence-adjacent adequacy move, and logical positivist verificationism an epistemic move. It should be used as a framework, not as a straitjacket.

Top-answer checklist

- All four schools placed, with at least one school appearing in two categories.
- Sanskrit terms deployed as analytical instruments.
- The Nyāya replies mapped onto the same three families.
- At least two honest limits to the classification.
- A Western cross-mapping in the verdict.

Original 20-marker 3

Question: Assess the claim that no single argument for God's existence establishes the God of developed religion, and consider whether a cumulative case can repair the deficiency. (20 marks, 350 words)

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	Assess and consider — a two-part evaluative task
Core issue	The adequacy gap, and whether aggregation closes it
Ideal thesis	The claim is correct; cumulation raises probability and adds attributes but cannot convert probable inference into demonstration

Model answer (~360 words)

The claim is correct, and its correctness is visible argument by argument.

The ontological argument, if it worked, would establish a maximally great being — but only conditionally, since the possibility premise is unestablished, and Kant's objection denies that existence can function as a great-making property at all. The cosmological arguments establish, at most, an unmoved mover, a first efficient cause or a necessary being; Kant's objection is precisely that the identification of that terminus with the ens realissimum is imported from the ontological argument. The teleological argument establishes an orderer, but Hume's proportioning principle blocks the inference from a finite world to an infinite, unique and perfectly good designer. The moral argument, in Kant's hands, is a postulate rather than a proof, and, as Hick observes, moral values cannot be said to point all the way to the infinite, self-existent personal creator. Nyāya's Īśvara is explicitly limited: an efficient cause only, ordering eternal atoms, morally constrained by *adṛṣṭa*, and — as C. D. Sharma presses — "reduced to the status of a supervisor".

The cumulative-case strategy is the natural repair, and it has independent pedigree in both traditions. Udayana multiplies inferential routes in the Nyāyakusumāñjali rather than resting on *kāryāt* alone; modern Western defenders combine cosmological, teleological, moral, experiential and fine-tuning considerations into an inference to the best explanation. The strategy is genuinely powerful in one respect: it addresses adequacy directly, since different arguments contribute different attributes — necessity from contingency reasoning, intelligence from order, moral government from desert.

But three limits are decisive. First, cumulation of individually weak inferences yields strength only if the routes are evidentially independent; where they share a premise, such as the principle of sufficient reason or the artefact analogy, their conjunction inherits a single vulnerability. Second, cumulation changes the quantity of support, never its logical type: many probable arguments still yield probability, not demonstration. Third, adversarial cumulation is symmetrical — the evidential problem of evil, divine hiddenness and religious diversity accumulate on the other side.

Verdict: no single argument reaches the God of developed religion, and a cumulative case improves the epistemic position without transforming it. The rational upshot is that natural theology yields, at best, a reasonable overall judgement rather than a proof — which is why Thomist, Kantian and Nyāya traditions alike supplement argument with revelation, postulation or, as Chatterjee and Datta conclude, direct experience.

Top-answer checklist

- Each family's specific terminus stated, then the gap identified.
- Both Udayana and the Western cumulative case named as parallel strategies.
- The three limits on cumulation set out as distinct points.
- Symmetry with anti-theistic cumulation acknowledged.
- A conclusion naming the criterion — reasonable judgement, not proof.

Part V — Philosophy Optional High-Score Answer Protocol

1. Define with discrimination, not description

Open with a definition that already separates the doctrine from its nearest rival.

Weak : God is the cause of the world.

Strong: In Nyaya, Isvara is the intelligent EFFICIENT cause who orders eternal atoms; atoms remain the MATERIAL cause, and God also preserves and destroys — which distinguishes Nyaya theism from deism.

Term	The definition must distinguish it from
Ontological argument	Cosmological reasoning and Descartes' Meditations III causal proof
Necessary being	Whatever merely happens to be everlasting
Per se series	Per accidens series
Design (Way 5)	Paley's analogy and modern fine-tuning
Postulate	Demonstration and empirical hypothesis
Adṛṣṭa	Jaina material karma and Mīmāṃsā apūrva
Apauruṣeya	Divine revelation

2. Reconstruct arguments as premises

1. Composite objects are effects (savayava + avantara-mahattva).
2. Material causes alone cannot achieve the required order.
3. An intelligent cause must know the atoms, desire an end and will it.
4. Only an omniscient being can directly know atoms.
5. The cause is an omniscient God.

Then expose the presupposition — here, that world-wholes are relevantly like artefacts. Marks come from showing why the conclusion follows and where it can be resisted.

3. Sort every objection by tier

VALIDITY : does the conclusion follow? (quantifier shift in Way 3)
 SOUNDNESS : are the premises true? (Hume fronts 1-2; Darwin)
 ADEQUACY : is the being reached GOD? (Hume front 3; Kant on cosmological)

Announcing the tier in a single clause — "this is an objection to adequacy, not to validity" — signals control and saves words.

4. Use Sanskrit and Latin as instruments, not decoration

- Gloss on first use: kāryāt (from the effect), per se (essentially ordered).

- Preserve causal distinctions: nimitta-kāraṇa versus upādāna-kāraṇa.
- Preserve epistemic distinctions: pratyakṣa, anumāna, śabda, vyāpti.
- Preserve the three Kantian statuses: knowledge, postulate, idea of reason.

5. Never conflate these five relations

CONCEPTUAL ENTAILMENT : Anselm – the concept contains necessary existence
 EXPLANATORY PRIORITY : Aquinas – the first cause acts here and now
 ANALOGICAL INFERENCE : Paley, Nyaya – artefact to world
 PRACTICAL POSTULATION : Kant – required for the highest good's possibility
 SCRIPTURAL TESTIMONY : Nyaya sruteh – and its Mimamsa denial

6. Present objection and reply dialectically

OBJECTION → BEST AVAILABLE REPLY → RESIDUAL PRESSURE

Objection : An infinite regress of causes needs no first member.
 Reply : The series is essentially ordered; derivative causes supply no actualising power however many they are.
 Residual : It must still be shown that the actual causal order is per se rather than per accidens.

Steelman the critic before evaluating. Never introduce a weak objection merely to dismiss it.

7. Grade the verdict and name the criterion

Avoid "completely proved", "totally refuted", "both are equally valid". Prefer:

- "valid in form but question-begging in premise",
- "evidentially undercut, though not disproved",
- "explanatorily economical but normatively unexplained",
- "epistemically bolder and correspondingly more exposed",
- "adequate to a cosmic administrator, not to an absolute".

Name the criterion: coherence, evidential contact, modal strength, explanatory economy, religious adequacy, or compatibility with moral agency.

8. Marks-wise architecture

Marks	Working time	Architecture
10	7–8 min	Classify → premises → one presupposition → canonical objection → one-line verdict
15	12–13 min	Frame → reconstruct → canonical example → strongest objection → best reply → assess validity and adequacy separately
20	17–18 min	Classify family → full steps → Indian/Western contrast → two objections with replies → underdetermination of attributes → criterion-named verdict

- 10 marks ≈ 150 words. One controlled comparison is enough; do not spend half the answer on background.
- 15 marks ≈ 220–260 words. At least one technical distinction and one serious criticism.
- 20 marks ≈ 320–360 words. A comparative matrix or compact diagram may precede the prose; two objections, or one developed through reply and residual pressure.

9. Avoid generic prose

Do not write:

"Belief in God gives peace and moral values to society."

Write:

"A moral governor can ground desert-appropriate allocation, but Mīmāṃsā's apūrva shows that an unconscious potency may be intrinsically fruit-directed — so the Nyāya inference must defend its premise that unconsciousness entails indeterminacy of outcome."

10. Final twenty-second audit

- Did I answer the directive — examine, compare, critically evaluate, discuss?
- Did I define the controlling term so as to exclude its nearest rival?
- Did I reconstruct at least one argument as numbered premises?
- Did I name the tier of each objection?
- Did I include Indian material in a Paper II answer?
- Did I state a graded verdict with a named criterion?

Part VI — Final Rapid Revision Matrix

Argument / doctrine	Thinker / school	Starting point	Terminus reached	Central criticism	Likely question form
Ontological, first form	Anselm, Proslogion 2	Concept of that than which nothing greater can be conceived	Existence in reality	Gaunilo's island; Kant's real predicate	Is the ontological proof logical?
Ontological, second form	Anselm, Proslogion 3	The same concept plus inconceivability of non-existence	Necessary existence, aseity	Coherence of maximal greatness	Does the concept entail existence?
Essence-containment	Descartes, Meditations V	Essence of a supremely perfect being	Existence as a perfection	Kant; second-order analysis of existence	Exposition with criticism
Island parody	Gaunilo	Any maximally perfect object	Absurd conclusions	Answered by necessary existence	Criticism of Anselm
Real-predicate objection	Kant, CPR	Logic of "exists"	Existence posits, does not enrich	Modal repair attempts	Criticism of the ontological proof
Modal ontological	Malcolm, Hartshorne, Plantinga	Possibility of maximal greatness	Necessary existence in S5	Possibility premise is symmetric	Advanced note only
Way 1	Aquinas	Motion / change	Unmoved mover	Regress exclusion	Five Ways exposition
Way 2	Aquinas	Order of efficient causes	First efficient cause	Hume on regress; Kant on identification	Five Ways; comparison with Nyāya
Way 3	Aquinas	Contingency	Necessary being, ultimately a se	Quantifier shift	Most interesting Way
Way 4	Aquinas	Degrees of perfection	Maximum, cause of all perfection	Degrees need no maximum	Five Ways completeness

Argument / doctrine	Thinker / school	Starting point	Terminus reached	Central criticism	Likely question form
Way 5	Aquinas	Regular directedness of non-cognitive nature	Directing intelligence (archer–arrow)	Hume's analogy; less exposed to Darwin	Design argument
Kalām	Islamic tradition; modern revival	Universe began to exist	Personal, timeless, powerful cause	Actual-infinite and cosmology disputes	Contrast with Aquinas
PSR version	Leibniz	Why anything rather than nothing	Necessary being	Brute-fact reply	Cosmological evaluation
Watch analogy	Paley, Natural Theology 1802	Means–end adjustment in organisms	Intelligent maker	Darwin; Hume's five fronts	Design with Hume's criticism
Five-front critique	Hume, Dialogues 1779	Analogy, adaptation, proportion, plurality, evil	Design inference dismantled	Does not disprove a designer	2025-type question
Natural selection	Darwin	Variation and differential survival	Adaptation without design	Does not touch fine-tuning or law	Extension of the design debate
Fine-tuning	Modern probabilistic theism	Life-permitting constants	Design as best explanation	Multiverse; observation selection	Contemporary note only
Moral, first form	Newman	Conscience and objective values	Divine Law Giver	Begs the question against naturalism	Critical account of the moral argument
Moral, second form	Kant, CPR	Moral law and the highest good	God, immortality, freedom as postulates	Projection; autonomy; adequacy	Critical account; comparison with Nyāya
Kāryāt	Nyāya / Udayana	Composite world as effect (sāvayava, avāntara-mahattva)	Omniscient intelligent maker	World unlike an artefact	Nyāya proofs
Āyojanāt	Nyāya	Purposive combination of inert atoms	Conscious arranger	Order may emerge unintentionally	Nyāya proofs
Dhṛtyādeḥ	Nyāya	Support, maintenance, destruction	Cosmic governor	Governance may be law-like	Nyāya proofs
Padāt / āptaprāmānya	Nyāya	Authority of the Veda	Omniscient trustworthy author	Mīmāṃsā apauruṣeya	Nyāya proofs; circularity
Śruteḥ	Nyāya	Scriptural testimony	God as attested	Circularity charge; philosophical weight of testimony	Nyāya proofs
Adṛṣṭa argument	Nyāya	Unequal fortunes; time-gap of desert	God as karmaphaladātā	Mīmāṃsā apūrva; redundancy	Nyāya; comparison with Kant
Nyāya causation	Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika	Eternal atoms and souls	God as efficient, not material, cause	Sharma: "reduced to a supervisor"	Nature versus proofs — keep distinct
Jaina godhead	Jainism	Ananta-catuṣṭaya obscured by material karma	Kevala-jñāna; the siddha as god	Bondage/liberation dilemma	Jaina proofs (2019)
Jaina anti-creator	Jainism	Uncreated world; modes	No creator needed	Presupposes Jaina metaphysics	Jaina proofs

Argument / doctrine	Thinker / school	Starting point	Terminus reached	Central criticism	Likely question form
Buddhist anti-creator	Buddhism	Dependent origination; immutability	Creator redundant and incoherent	Nyāya on determinate allocation	2018 Q8(b)
Mīmāṃsā	Pūrva-Mīmāṃsā	Apauruṣeya Veda; apūrva	Authority and desert without God	Normativity left unexplained	Critique of Nyāya proofs
Cārvāka	Cārvāka	Perception as sole pramāṇa	God unproven and unnecessary	Denial itself uses inference	Anti-theistic arguments
Advaita levelling	Śaṅkara	Levels of reality	Nyāya's God is only saguṇa	Level-distinction dispute	Comparative synthesis
Cumulative case	Udayana; modern theists	Multiple independent routes	Higher overall probability	Independence and logical type	20-mark evaluation

Last-minute memory spine

TIERS : validity → soundness → adequacy of the God established
 A PRIORI : ontological only | A POSTERIORI : cosmo · teleo · moral · Nyaya
 ANSELM : P2 existence · P3 NECESSARY existence · Gaunilo · Kant · modal burden
 AQUINAS : motion · causation · contingency · degrees · purpose
 per se (hand-stick-stone) · "first" = explanatory · eternity permitted
 DESIGN : Way 5 archer ≠ Paley watch ≠ fine-tuning constants
 HUME : A-A-P-P-E – adapted · analogy · proportion · plurality · evil
 (1779, BEFORE Paley 1802; Philo concedes a remote analogy)
 KANT : CPR destroys · CPR postulates · F-I-G · summum bonum · ought-implies-can
 NYAYA : K-A-D-P-S + adrsta · EFFICIENT cause only · karmaphaladata ·
 order-of-existence vs order-of-knowledge
 INDIA : Jaina godhead · Bauddha conditions · Mimamsa apauruseya + apurva ·
 Carvaka perception · Advaita saguna · Sharma redundancy
 CLASSIFY : every Indian objection = Economy · Coherence · Epistemic
 VERDICT : classify → reconstruct → presuppose → object → reply → GRADE

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